THIRSTYGIRL

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A note on nudity:

Unless specified by ***bold italics*,** nudity will be implied and will not include actors' breasts or front/back of pelvis.

0 INT. OVER BLACK

MAN (V.O.)
You dirty little slut. Yeah, that's right. You like this, don't you.

We hear a woman moan. She's got something in her mouth.

MAN (V.O.)
Yeah. You want to get fucked like a dirty whore? You're such a nasty little bitch. Fuck. Oh yeah, that's good. You can't get enough, you fucking slut.

Another man's voice comes in. And then another. It's three men talking to us now.

THE THREE MEN (V.O.)
You disgusting bitch. Take it. Fuck yeah. You want some more? You're fucking wild, aren't you?

1 INT. CHARLIE'S BIRTHDAY BAR, BATHROOM STALL - NIGHT

CHARLIE XU (32) sits on the toilet with her earbuds in, watching her phone intensely.

We hear nothing but the three men speaking to us.

Charlie closes her eyes. And starts to touch herself. Gradually, the men's dialogue changes from pornographic to... something else.

THE THREE MEN (V.O.)
I love you. I fucking love you so much. Oh yeah, just like that. I love you, you dirty fucking slut.

This crescendos until the three men are saying "I love you" over and over as Charlie gets closer and closer--

A loud vibrating noise interrupts us. Charlie opens her eyes. Over a paused gangbang porn video, an incoming call from NIC. Her contact photo shows a young Asian woman who looks a lot like Charlie.

Charlie stares at the incoming call. And clicks IGNORE.

Charlie turns her gaze up beyond her phone. A big red stall door. We can hear the crowded bar bathroom noise now.

Charlie returns her gaze to her phone and presses PLAY on the video. Right then--

FEMALE FRIEND (O.S.)
Charlie!

Charlie looks up. Then back at her phone. Her friend starts banging loudly on the bathroom stall door.

FEMALE FRIEND (O.S.)
Charlie, we're doing the cake!

CHARLIE
I'm taking a shit, do it without me!

FEMALE FRIEND (O.S.)
It's *your* birthday!

Charlie's head falls back against the wall. She pauses the video and removes her hand from her underwear. She places her phone on her bare lap.

A "New voicemail from Nic" notification appears.

Some white powder starts to fall on the screen. It turns into a thin, expertly drawn, white line.

FEMALE FRIEND (O.S.)
Charlie, come on!

CHARLIE
I'm coming, I'm coming.

Charlie bends over to snort the line off her phone. She sits up, wipes the powder from her nose, and gets up off the toilet. We stay on her panties. Over this crotch shot:

THIRSTYGIRL

2 EXT. CHARLIE'S BIRTHDAY BAR - NIGHT

Charlie stands outside the bar, wearing a birthday hat with the number "32" on it. She lights a Marlboro Gold.

On her phone, she notices the new voicemail message from NIC. Her voicemail is also filled with hundreds of unheard messages from DAD.

Charlie opens the Find My app. Nic's blue dot is a few blocks away.

As she takes another drag from her cigarette, she spots a man walking towards her.

MIGUEL (31, attractive, wearing all black) walks right past Charlie and into the bar next door. She turns her head to check him out as he does. We linger on his body.

Right then, he turns around and looks back at her. They lock eyes. And he disappears into the bar.

Charlie's eyes tense up. We start to hear a **DEEP BASS RUMBLE.** It's barely there, but we can definitely hear it (*henceforth, this sound will be known as the* ***RUMBLE****).*

A black car parks in front of her.

UBER DRIVER (O.S.)
Charlie?

3 INT. MIGUEL'S BAR - NIGHT

The **RUMBLE** has stopped. Miguel stands at the bar, waiting for his drink.

After a while, Charlie, now without her birthday hat, walks up to the bar and stands one person away from him.

The person standing between them takes their drink and walks away.

Charlie turns and looks straight at Miguel. Miguel turns and looks back at Charlie.

4 INT/EXT. WILLIAMSBURG BRIDGE, UBER - NIGHT

Charlie lays down on the back seat, with Miguel on top of her, his hands around her neck, their bodies so fucking close to each other. He starts to choke her, whispering--

MIGUEL
Yeah, you like that?

CHARLIE
(nods)
Mhmmm...

SLAP! Miguel slaps Charlie in the face. Startled, Charlie takes a breath, then looks back at him with intense desire.

Through the window, the Manhattan skyline drifts by as the car drives over the Williamsburg Bridge.

5 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, BEDROOM - DAY

Charlie sits up on the side of the bed, wearing a big T-shirt and underwear, exhausted. Miguel lays asleep face down next to her, naked, the sheets pulled down ***under his ass.***

6 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, BATHROOM - DAY

Charlie inspects herself in the mirror. Big bruises on her neck. This is not good.

7 INT. SUBWAY STATION - DAY

Charlie runs frantically down the subway station stairs.

CHARLIE
Please, please, please.

8 INT. SUBWAY STATION, TRAIN PLATFORM - DAY

The train pulls out just as Charlie gets to the platform.

CHARLIE
Fuck!

9 INT. TECH OFFICE, BIG CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

A bunch of TECH GUYS sit quietly around a big table, on their phones.

At the head of the table, an empty seat.

ARJUN PATEL (38, wearing a suit, clearly in charge) sits at the other end, livid.

Charlie rushes in, flushed and out of breath. She sits down.

CHARLIE
Sorry, I'm so sorry.

ARJUN
Apologies for the wait, folks. Brilliant coders. They're on their own frequency.

Charlie takes her laptop out. As she types quickly, code on her screen mirrors on the big monitor behind her. An impressive virtual environment loads up as Arjun goes on--

ARJUN
As I was saying, we're really proud of this new model. We expect it to outperform competitors as soon as we release it next week. And to demo how it works, our VP of Engineering, Charlie Xu.

Charlie takes a breath. And she locks in.

CHARLIE
Welcome to the future of cybersecurity--

10 INT. TECH OFFICE, BIG CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

The room has emptied. Charlie stands alone at the head of the table. Arjun stands across the table from her.

ARJUN
Gary's going to take over.

CHARLIE
What?! Why? That went great. They loved it.

ARJUN
Are you for real? You made our investors wait a half an hour. You look like shit. You smell like a fucking dive bar. And it's not just today.

Charlie stares at him.

ARJUN
Do you not care that we're about to sell? Everything you and I and everyone else here has worked for, for years--

CHARLIE
Of course I care. Do you think we'd have anything worth selling if not for my work? And... Gary?
(makes a face)
Are you fucking serious?

Through the conference room glass walls, GARY (40s, very mediocre), hears his name and waves at Charlie with a smile.

ARJUN
Is that a hickey?

CHARLIE
What?

Charlie covers her bruises with her hand.

Arjun walks up to her and moves her hand away slowly. He inspects her neck, standing a little too close to her. Their eyes meet. They've clearly been here before.

ARJUN
Jesus, Charlie.

We catch a glimpse of Arjun's wedding band as he removes his hand from her neck and paces away.

ARJUN
Look, I know you've had a... tough year. But I don't have a choice. This is too important. So, we'll give you a really generous severance package. And you can keep all your stock options through the sale. It'll be good for you. You can take time off.

This horrifying possibility lands on Charlie. The **RUMBLE** creeps back in.

CHARLIE
Listen. I know I've been a mess and I've been dropping the ball. But it's over now. You can count on me. I swear. I can do this. I need to do this. Please. After everything...
(hesitates)
Please. Arjun.

Charlie gets close to Arjun and tugs gently at his tie.

Arjun looks down at her.

He slides his tie away from her hand.

He walks to the door. Before stepping out--

ARJUN
Monday morning. The model release. I need you here at 9 AM. Sharp. And it needs to go flawlessly. Understood? If you have to stay here with the entire engineering team through the weekend, so be it.

CHARLIE
Absolutely. Yes. Done.

ARJUN
Please don't make me fire you, Charlie.

Arjun walks out. Charlie stands frozen for a few moments.

11 INT. TECH OFFICE, CHARLIE'S DESK - DAY

Charlie sits down at her desk. The **RUMBLE** is louder now.

On her monitor, a wall of code. Slack notifications tagging Charlie, asking for code reviews.

She opens Tinder on her phone. Swipes on guy after guy. No. No. Yes. No.

An incoming call from AGNES LAWYER interrupts her. Charlie stares at it. She clicks IGNORE and goes back to swiping.

A sudden scowl on her face.

SOME GUY (TINDER DM)
I love Chinese food ;)

She shakes her head and swipes him away.

Hmmmm, this one looks cute. AKEEM (30) from Brooklyn. She swipes right. Immediately--

AKEEM (TINDER DM)
Hey :)

AKEEM (TINDER DM)
What are u doing right now?

Charlie stares at her phone intensely. The **RUMBLE** eases. She jolts up, packs up her things and leaves, everyone else still hard at work.

12 INT. SUBWAY TRAIN - DAY

Charlie sits on a packed train during rush hour. She stares at various men, lingering on their body parts. A MAN IN A SUIT in his 50s. A YOUNG GUY WITH TATTOOS all over. A LARGER-BODIED BEARDED GUY.

13 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Charlie rushes into the apartment, holding a big yellow envelope and a drugstore bag.

In a corner, some moving boxes.

Charlie tears the envelope open with her teeth. A stack of legal documents. On the front page:

DANIELS VS. XU

Charlie stares at the papers. And throws them in the trash.

She takes her phone out and presses PLAY on a voicemail from AGNES LAWYER. She darts into the bedroom.

14 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, VARIOUS - NIGHT

The voicemail plays over a montage of Charlie getting ready.

AGNES LAWYER (VOICEMAIL)
Charlie. This is the third message I'm leaving you today. Please call me back. You should have received the new agreement. You need to review it before next week's hearing.

Charlie picks up last night's clothes from the floor. She finds Miguel's boxers.

Charlie stands in front of her unmade bed. A big cum stain on the dark sheets. She turns the comforter over.

Charlie opens her bathroom closet. A stack of Plan B pills. She takes one.

In her bra and underwear, she waves palo santo around the living room as she brushes her teeth.

Back by the bed, she tears open a condom box. She pours some condoms on one of the end tables. Then pours some more on the other end table.

15 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, BATHROOM - NIGHT

In the bathroom, in her date outfit, she covers up her bruises with makeup. It sort of works. She starts to do her lipstick. She yawns.

She opens the mirror cabinet and grabs a small vial of white powder. She pours a bump onto her hand, on the soft space between her thumb and index finger. She snorts it.

AGNES LAWYER (VOICEMAIL)
And I have to say this again, as your attorney, I strongly advise you to try to settle this via mediation. This could turn very ugly and expensive and I'm worried that you might lose everything you've worked very hard for... Just call me back when you can--

Charlie deletes the voicemail as she wipes the powder from under her nose. And finishes her lipstick.

16 INT. AKEEM DATE BAR - NIGHT

Charlie sits across from AKEEM in a small, cozy booth. They sip on hazy pints of beer, smiling at each other. Charlie's phone is on the table. It vibrates. It's NIC calling.

AKEEM (O.S.)
Aries?

Charlie clicks IGNORE on her phone.

CHARLIE
Yeah. Aries. Why?

AKEEM
Oof. That's bad. Aries are crazy.

CHARLIE
(laughs)
What? What are you?

AKEEM
Sagittarius.

CHARLIE
Sagittarius... Hmm... Sagittarius are really bad in bed, right?

AKEEM
(laughs)
Actually Sagittarius are very playful. Very generous.

CHARLIE
Generous? That's good.

Charlie's phone vibrates again. It's still NIC. She clicks IGNORE.

AKEEM
Do you need to get that?

CHARLIE
No, it's just my sister.

AKEEM
A sister. Older or younger? Wait, let me guess.
(beat)
You're the older sister.

Charlie smiles.

CHARLIE
Yeah.

AKEEM
I knew it. Are you close with your family?

CHARLIE
(uncomfortable)
Not really. You?

AKEEM
Yeah, for sure. I'm really close with my mom. And I have three sisters. We're all really close.

Charlie nods, feigning interest.

CHARLIE
You know, I live right upstairs.

17 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, BEDROOM - NIGHT

It's dark. Charlie lays in bed awake, on her phone. Akeem is asleep next to her.

On **pornhub.com**, Charlie searches "submissive". She scrolls through the videos until she finds the right one.

She glances back at Akeem. She mutes her phone. And slides her hand under the covers.

18 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, BEDROOM - DAY

Charlie wakes up. Akeem is still there, asleep next to her.

She grabs her phone from the end table. Some open condom wrappers fall off.

On her phone: 3 new missed calls from NIC.

AKEEM (O.S.)
Good morning.

19 INT. CHARLIE'S APARTMENT, BATHROOM - DAY

Charlie brushes her teeth, the door left ajar. Akeem is still in bed.

AKEEM
Last night was fun. We should do this again sometime.

CHARLIE
(unenthused)
Yeah, for sure.

Charlie sits on the toilet and starts to pee.

She gets a call from an UNKNOWN NUMBER. She hesitates. Still peeing, she answers it.

CHARLIE
Hello?

SOCIAL WORKER (V.O.)
Hello, is this Charlotte Xu?

AKEEM (O.S.)
How about some pancakes?

CHARLIE
Yes, this is she.

SOCIAL WORKER (V.O.)
I'm calling from Beth Israel Hospital. Your sister Nicole is here. She was checked in early this morning--

20 INT. EMERGENCY ROOM, ENTRANCE - DAY

Hospital chaos all around. Charlie stands at the front desk, where a female HOSPITAL RECEPTIONIST (50s) looks too busy to talk to her.

HOSPITAL RECEPTIONIST
(types on her computer)
I don't see her in here.

CHARLIE
Nicole Xu?
(leans over to look at the screen)
No, it's spelled X-U. It's Chinese.

HOSPITAL RECEPTIONIST
(types again)
Take a seat, honey. Someone'll come get you.

Charlie sits down. She scans the room. The people sitting next to her look depressing as hell.

Among them, a WOMAN WITH TRACK MARKS (40s) on her arms, who seems to be in withdrawal from heroin.

Charlie can see some of the ER beds from where she sits. A nurse moves out of her line of sight to reveal a patient with pink hair.

Charlie recognizes her. She darts up and walks over.

21 INT. EMERGENCY ROOM, NIC'S BED - DAY

Faded pink hair with overgrown dark brown roots. Lots of piercings on her ears. A glimpse of a tattoo on her neck. Smudged eye makeup.

NIC (25), is asleep. A very deep sleep. She's wearing a hospital gown and has a hospital tag on her wrist. And there's a scary looking IV line sticking into her arm, hooked up to a bag filled with neon yellow fluid.

Nic's things are on the chair next to the bed. A bright blue bomber jacket. A little black backpack. Old Dr. Martens with traces of dried vomit on them. Actually, there's vomit on all of her stuff.

Charlie stands by Nic's bed, looking at her with worry. She notices something on the inside of Nic's arm. She rolls it over. A tattoo that says: **GOD, grant me the serenity to--**

SOCIAL WORKER (O.S.)
Charlotte Xu?

22 INT. EMERGENCY ROOM, SOCIAL WORKER'S OFFICE - DAY

Charlie sits across from the SOCIAL WORKER (30s, wears a hijab) at her desk. Her office is tiny and depressing. There are cheesy self-love quotes all over the wall behind her.

CHARLIE
She was five years sober.

SOCIAL WORKER
Relapse is a part of recovery.

CHARLIE
I don't understand. What happened?

The office phone rings. It's very loud and annoying. The social worker picks up.

SOCIAL WORKER
Beth Israel Emergency Room Social Work Department. What flavors do they have?
(listens)
Chubby hubby. No, Cherry Garcia. Okay, thanks.
(hangs up, to Charlie)
I'm sorry, a celebrity gifted an ice cream truck to the hospital staff today and it's only here for the next half-hour. What was your question?

CHARLIE
What happened?

SOCIAL WORKER
You'll have to ask her. She was unconscious when she was checked in.

CHARLIE
Jesus.

SOCIAL WORKER
Her blood alcohol content was quite elevated. And the tox screen revealed various narcotics in her system.

CHARLIE
Fuck! Sorry... What now?

The phone rings again. Somehow it's louder than before. The social worker picks up while mouthing "sorry" to Charlie.

SOCIAL WORKER
Beth Israel Emergency Room Social Work Department. Well then, why didn't you tell me that to begin with, Raul? So, what flavors?

Charlie's eyes glaze over to the posters on the wall.

"I am more than my scars"

"It takes courage to heal"

"How you love yourself is how you teach others to love you"

SOCIAL WORKER (O.S.)
Chunky Monkey then.
(hangs up, to Charlie)
Charlie.

Charlie places her attention back on the social worker.

SOCIAL WORKER
Do you know when this relapse started?

CHARLIE
No.

SOCIAL WORKER
When was the last time you spoke with her?

CHARLIE
I don't know. Her birthday. Six months ago?

SOCIAL WORKER
Was she sober then?

CHARLIE
Yeah, she was doing great. I think.

SOCIAL WORKER
Well, I strongly suggest you consider an addiction treatment center. There are a number of options around New York.

The social worker places some pamphlets in front of Charlie.

CHARLIE
Fuck! Sorry, sorry.
(a deep breath)
(MORE)

CHARLIE (CONT'D)
Does she have to go right away? Or can it wait?

SOCIAL WORKER
I don’t recommend waiting.

The phone rings again.

SOCIAL WORKER
She got very lucky. She might not be so lucky next time.
(answers the phone)
Damnit, Raul! Any flavor is fine! Oh, sorry Mrs. Brown. Yes, your son is here.

Charlie stares anxiously at the pamphlets on the desk.

23 EXT. EMERGENCY ROOM ENTRANCE - DAY

Charlie smokes a cigarette outside the hospital, the **RUMBLE** playing over the sounds of the street.

She checks her phone.

ARJUN (PHONE TEXT)
Hate how we left things yesterday.

ARJUN (PHONE TEXT)
Metrics review over drinks tonight?

Charlie looks up. She sees an ATTRACTIVE MAN (30s) smoking a cigarette on the other side of the entrance.

The **RUMBLE** stops. Everything else fades away.

We inspect his body slowly and then stay on his mouth as he smokes his cigarette.

JUMP CUT TO: A 1 second slow-motion shot of Charlie going down on him.

HOSPITAL RECEPTIONIST (O.S.)
Hey! You can’t smoke out here!

Startled, Charlie turns around.

HOSPITAL RECEPTIONIST
Who do you think you are? This is a damn hospital!

Charlie puts out her cigarette in a panic. She looks back to where the other smoker was standing. He's gone. She looks back at her phone.

ARJUN (PHONE TEXT)
Metrics review over drinks tonight?

Charlie types something. She pauses. A look of dread.

MOM's contact info is pulled up.

24 INT. EMERGENCY ROOM, ENTRANCE - DAY

Charlie paces around the waiting room on her phone.

MOM (V.O.)
How did this happen?

CHARLIE
I don't know. She's still asleep.

MOM (V.O.)
I can't go through this again.

Charlie takes a deep breath.

CHARLIE
We should send her to that place in Kentucky.

MOM (V.O.)
The Bridge?

CHARLIE
Yeah. It's the only place that worked on her. She likes it there. It has horses. I already called them. We can check her in tomorrow.

MOM (V.O.)
Fine.

CHARLIE
Can you fly here tonight and drive her over in the morning?

MOM (V.O.)
No. Charlotte. I can't.

CHARLIE
Mom. I wouldn't ask you, but I can't leave right now. I just have too much going on with work.

MOM (V.O.)
I can’t. You know I have the cats.

Charlie looks up, frustrated.

MOM (V.O.)
What about Oliver? Can’t he help?

Charlie hangs on the phone for a moment.

CHARLIE
He’s... out of town. For work. Can you just get a cat sitter and come?

MOM
Charlotte...

CHARLIE
Please--

MOM (V.O.)
(screaming, monster-like)
CHARLOTTE! I AM ALREADY PAYING FOR EVERYTHING! WHAT MORE DO YOU WANT FROM ME?

Charlie stands there, speechless, terrified.

MOM (V.O.)
... I have to go.

CHARLIE
Mom, please, we can’t leave her alone. You know that--

Mom has hung up. Charlie stands there, as all the ER chaos gets louder and louder around her.

25 INT. EMERGENCY ROOM, NIC'S BED - DAY

Charlie walks back over to Nic’s bed.

Nic isn’t there. Charlie looks around in a panic.

NIC (O.S.)
Charlie?

Nic stands a few feet away, wearing only a hospital gown and pink socks, holding an ice cream cup. Charlie rushes up to her and hugs her way too tight.

CHARLIE
Fuck. I was so worried.

NIC
You're hurting me.

CHARLIE
Good.

Nic climbs back into bed.

Charlie sits down next to her. They stay like this in tense silence for a bit.

CHARLIE
I like the pink. Last time I saw you, it was blue.

NIC
That was like two hairs ago.

More silence.

CHARLIE
What happened?

Nic digs into her ice cream.

CHARLIE
Nic.

NIC
Promise you'll believe me?

CHARLIE
Yes.

NIC
Promise?

CHARLIE
I promise.

A beat.

NIC
I was walking home from my friend's place. Late. And out of nowhere, this guy creeps up on me from behind and pushes me up against a wall.

CHARLIE
What?

NIC
So I'm terrified, I'm like frozen. And he's holding a bottle of Jack Daniels. And then he takes out a gun. And he points it at me. And he says: "Bitch, you either drink this or I shoot you in the motherfuckin' face."

Charlie smiles.

NIC
Swear to God! And I say to him: "Please sir, I'm five years sober, I can't. I'd rather die than lose my sobriety. Here, take my wallet, take my phone, take everything, but please, not this."

CHARLIE
Okay, got it.

NIC
Wait, I'm not done. So I'm telling him no, I'm holding strong. But then, he points the gun at a dog!

CHARLIE
What kind of dog?

NIC
Labradoodle mix.

CHARLIE
A stray labradoodle?

NIC
Brooklyn. It's wild out there.

Charlie laughs.

NIC
So I had to! To save the dog. A worthy sacrifice.

CHARLIE
Are you done?

Nic smiles.

CHARLIE
They're gonna love that story at the Bridge.

Nic’s smile disappears.

NIC
No...

CHARLIE
Yup. 30 days.

NIC
But it was just a slip. I’m fine!

Charlie looks at Nic, fragile and tiny in her hospital bed, and clearly very *not* fine.

CHARLIE
What happened?

NIC
I told you, he had a gun--

CHARLIE
Can you please be serious?

NIC
Can you please chill out?

CHARLIE
What about this is chill? After everything... I don’t understand. Why would you do this?

NIC
Yeah, you don’t understand. So can you just not, right now?

More silence.

NIC
Did you talk to Mom?

CHARLIE
Yeah.

NIC
Is she coming?

Charlie doesn’t say anything.

NIC
She’s not coming?

Charlie looks down.

Nic starts to cry. Charlie moves to comfort her.

NIC
I'm sorry I'm such a fuck up. And I ruined your birthday weekend.

CHARLIE
It's okay. It's gonna be okay. You're gonna go to the Bridge for a while and you'll get better.

NIC
(wipes the tears away)
Okay. I'm sorry.

CHARLIE
I thought you were doing good.

Nic doesn't respond.

Suddenly, Nic groans very loudly while grabbing the sides of her head.

NIC
Aaaaah!

CHARLIE
What's wrong?!

NIC
Brain freeze!

Charlie shoves Nic's head playfully. Nic shoves Charlie back.

NIC
Can we go? I fucking hate it here. It smells like vomit.

CHARLIE
Not yet. You took a lot of shit. You need to detox.

NIC
Pff. Detox. I'm barely hungover.

Charlie smiles and shakes her head.

26 INT. EMERGENCY ROOM, HALLWAY - DAY

Charlie and Nic roll around in wheelchairs in an empty hallway. Nic drags her IV bag along with her.

They crash into each other.

NIC
Bitch! I'm unwell. Be careful.
(beat)
Hey, is it cool if I stay at yours tonight? My place is kinda... relapse-y.

Charlie stops rolling around. Guilt in her eyes.

CHARLIE
Well, your flight to Louisville is at nine.

NIC
(freaking out)
What?

NIC
No fucking way!

CHARLIE
I know you don't like to fly--

NIC
I'm not getting on a plane! Period. Why don't we just drive there like last time?

Charlie goes silent. Nic realizes what this means.

NIC
Oh. You're not coming.

CHARLIE
I promise, I would if I could. We have this huge release on Monday that we've been working on all year and if it doesn't go well, it could tank our sale price, and--

NIC
Okay.

CHARLIE
I'm sorry.

NIC
It's okay. I'll be fine.

The social worker walks over.

SOCIAL WORKER
Nicole? You're good to go.

Charlie looks at Nic with guilt.

NIC
I'll be fine!

Nic rolls off down the hall.

27 EXT. AIRPORT, DROP-OFF AREA - NIGHT

A plane lands on the tarmac in the distance.

Charlie takes Nic's suitcase out of the trunk of an Uber.

Nic stands there, looking apprehensively at the airport entrance.

CHARLIE
Call me when you land, okay?

Nic nods. It's clear she's freaking out.

Charlie can see this. Still, she hugs Nic goodbye.

28 INT/EXT. AIRPORT, UBER - NIGHT

Charlie sits in the back seat. As the car drives away, she turns around to watch Nic through the rear window.

Nic stands in front of the airport doors. She is not moving at all.

Charlie watches this anxiously. She turns back around to face the front.

She takes a deep breath.

She turns around again. Nic still isn't moving. As Nic gets smaller and smaller, Charlie's eyes get more and more distressed.

29 INT/EXT. NEW JERSEY HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - DAWN

A shitty rental car. Like a Ford Fiesta.

Charlie breaks a little too hard. She clearly isn't used to driving.

Nic, shoes off, feet up, switches through songs on her phone.

CHARLIE
Can you just pick one?

NIC
Sorry...

Nic lands on a K-Pop song. Charlie grimaces.

Awkward silence between them. Then, both at once--

NIC
How's work?

CHARLIE
How's school?

Nic rolls her eyes towards the window as if to say "Kill me."

CHARLIE
It's good. I'm the VP of Engineering now. It's a lot of work but it's going really well.

NIC
I thought you were already the VP of Engineering.

CHARLIE
No, I was the Director of Engineering.

NIC
What's the difference?

Charlie thinks for a moment. Nic laughs.

CHARLIE
Shut up, there's a difference!
(beat)
How's school? Wait. Did you call them?

NIC
What?

CHARLIE
Columbia. Did you ask them for permission to take time off?

NIC
Oh. I don't have to ask them.

CHARLIE
Why not?

NIC
Punch buggy blue!

Nic punches Charlie in what seems to be the pelvic area.

CHARLIE
Ow! What the fuck! There's not even a bug!

NIC
I play with Teslas.
(beat)
I took the semester off.

CHARLIE
What? When?

NIC
I don't know. Last semester.

CHARLIE
You didn't tell me.

Nic goes back on her phone. More awkward silence.

BUZZ. A Tinder notification on Charlie's phone: **"You have a new match."** Charlie stares at it for a couple seconds. She goes back to focusing on the road. The **RUMBLE** emerges, subtly.

NIC
(yawns)
Why did we have to leave so early?

CHARLIE
I have to be back for the product release tomorrow morning.

NIC
How are you going to make that?

CHARLIE
There's a flight to New York from Louisville tonight at 1 AM.

NIC
Isn't this like a twenty hour drive?

CHARLIE
Thirteen without stops. And it would be a lot easier if you could help but you're still somehow a useless twenty-five year old baby without a driver's license.

NIC
It's not my fault my road test guy was racist!
(MORE)

NIC (CONT'D)
(beat)
What's that on your neck?

Nic touches Charlie's bruise.

CHARLIE
Stop! Nothing.

Nic goes back to switching through songs.

BUZZ. Another Tinder notification on Charlie's phone. **"You have 5 unread messages!"** Some work Slack notifications come in too. Charlie stares at them nervously.

The song switching gets more and more grating.

Charlie finally snaps and swats Nic's hand away.

Another long silence.

CHARLIE
Did you call your sponsor?

NIC
Um no.

CHARLIE
Don't you think maybe you should call her?

NIC
I haven't really talked to her in a while.

CHARLIE
Why not?

NIC
I haven't been going to meetings lately.

CHARLIE
What?

NIC
Punch buggy silver!

Nic punches Charlie in the pelvic area again.

CHARLIE
Ow! Stop that!
(beat)
(MORE)

CHARLIE (CONT'D)
So you haven’t been going to school and you haven’t been going to meetings? What do you do all day?

NIC
I’ve been volunteering for this nonprofit that provides services for troubled youth.

Charlie raises her eyebrows, holding back laughter.

NIC
What?

CHARLIE
Aren’t you the troubled youth?

NIC
Is this you tryna be funny?

Charlie laughs.

CHARLIE
Punch buggy!

NIC
Punch buggy red!

They simultaneously punch each other in the pelvic area. Both squirm in pain and laugh. As Nic looks up--

NIC
Charlie!

Charlie looks ahead, notices the car she’s about to hit.

SCREECH! She slams the breaks, narrowly avoiding an accident.

CHARLIE
Look what you did!

NIC
You punched me!

CHARLIE
You’re distracting me! With your stupid games and changing the music every second like a psycho!

NIC
It’s not my fault, I have ADHD!

CHARLIE
Since when?

NIC
Since always! And you shouldn’t say “psycho”, it’s ableist!

BUZZ. It’s Charlie’s phone. An incoming call from DAD.

Charlie and Nic both stare at it in silence. After a few rings, Charlie clicks IGNORE.

The most awkward silence yet.

NIC
You still haven’t talked to him?

CHARLIE
No. You?

NIC
No.

BUZZ. More Tinder and Slack notification. The **RUMBLE** gets louder.

Charlie spots a sign for a gas station coming up.

30 EXT. NJ STRIP MALL GAS STATION - DAY

The car pulls up into a deserted gas station.

31 INT/EXT. NJ STRIP MALL GAS STATION, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Charlie stops the car. Nic looks up at the dashboard. The tank is still mostly full.

NIC
Why are we stopping?

CHARLIE
I gotta go to the bathroom.

NIC
Already?

Charlie ignores Nic and gets out of the car.

32 INT. NJ STRIP MALL GAS STATION, BATHROOM - DAY

Charlie rushes in. Her hands are shaking. The **RUMBLE** is much louder now.

She pulls out her phone. She swipes away the work Slack notifications. Opens Tinder. A sigh of relief. The **RUMBLE** disappears.

Charlie looks up. The bathroom is disgusting. It's the most disgusting gas station bathroom we've ever seen. And it smells terrible.

Charlie walks up to the toilet. It is clogged full of human shit. She grimaces. She checks her Tinder DMs.

She swipes through cheesy pick-up lines. Swipe. Swipe. Swipe. Hm. Charlie stares at her phone with an interested smile.

HOT GUY (TINDER DM)
I'd love to see you naked.

Charlie types a response.

CHARLIE (TINDER DM)
That can be arranged.

She hits SEND. Almost immediately, Hot Guy starts to type a response back. After a few seconds--

HOT GUY (TINDER DM)
What do you look like now?

Charlie smiles. She takes a selfie of herself biting her lower lip and sends it to him.

HOT GUY (TINDER DM)
Yum. Show me more.

Charlie beams with excitement. She rolls her shirt up ***above her tits. She's not wearing a bra.*** She takes a few selfies and sends one.

HOT GUY (TINDER DM)
Heart eyes emoji
Stick tongue out emoji

HOT GUY (TINDER DM)
More.

CHARLIE (TINDER DM)
Your turn.

After a moment, the phone buzzes. Charlie's eyes widen.

She puts her phone down on the sink. She rushes to take her bottoms off. She kicks off her shoes while pulling her pants down, almost knocking her phone off the sink.

She takes her underwear off. She grabs her phone and takes a few shots, bending over to try to get a good angle. She reviews them. She frowns.

Charlie stops and thinks for a moment.

She walks over to the toilet and puts her foot on the toilet paper dispenser. She positions her phone. She smiles. This is the angle.

She takes a few photos. She leans on her leg a little more to take the perfect pussy pic--

CLANG! The toilet paper dispenser falls off the wall and Charlie falls over, hitting the wall with her face.

SPLASH! Her phone falls into the shit-filled toilet.

CHARLIE
No, no, no, no, no.

Charlie panics. She grabs the toilet paper from the floor and wraps her hand in as much of it as she can.

The shit-filled toilet bowl.

Charlie's horrified face.

The shit-filled toilet bowl.

Charlie puts her TP-wrapped hand into the toilet and fishes around. This is so gross. Her eyes widen. She has it!

She rushes to the sink. She pours as much soap as she can on her hands and phone and runs the water. She scrubs vigorously.

She lifts her hands and phone to her nose. *Ew.* She can still smell it. She washes them some more.

As she washes, her phone <u>turns off</u>.

CHARLIE
No!

Charlie tries to turn her phone on. Nothing

CHARLIE
Shit!

Charlie turns the hand dryer on and dries her phone under it impatiently. She tries to turn her phone on again. Over a black screen, a water drop icon appears.

CHARLIE
No! Aren't you waterproof?

Charlie runs her phone under the hand dryer again.

33 INT. NJ STRIP MALL GROCERY STORE - DAY

Charlie power walks through grocery store aisles, looking for something.

Down one aisle. Down another.

Finally, she finds what she's looking for. A wall of rice boxes. She grabs one.

As she does, a hand reaches over her to grab another box.

A MAN SHOPPING (40s), standing right behind her, puts the rice in his basket and then disappears around the corner.

Charlie stands frozen for a moment. Then decides to follow him. She walks down the aisle slowly and peeks around the corner.

She watches him browse the frozen foods section.

33A **JUMP CUT TO:** A 1 second slow-motion shot of him fucking Charlie against the freezers.

LITTLE GIRL SHOPPING (O.S.)
Daddy!

Two little girls run right past Charlie towards Man Shopping. One of the girls is holding a box of cookies.

LITTLE GIRL SHOPPING
Daddy, we found them!

The two little girls run into his arms. They walk away, holding hands, like the best family in the world.

Charlie stands between the aisles watching the scene.

34 EXT. NJ STRIP MALL GAS STATION, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Charlie walks back towards the car, holding a shopping bag.

Nic, standing by the car, snaps at her immediately.

NIC
What took you so long?!

CHARLIE
I had to go to the store.

NIC
I went looking for you!

CHARLIE
I was right there!

NIC
I called you! Why is your location sharing off?

CHARLIE
My phone died!

NIC
You can't leave me alone like that!

CHARLIE
I'm sorry! I'm sorry! I won't.

Nic gets back in the car, slamming the door.

35 INT/EXT. NJ STRIP MALL GAS STATION, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Nic sits in her seat, angry. Charlie gets in the car.

Tense silence. Charlie tries to turn her phone on again. Nothing.

She fills a sandwich bag with rice and puts her phone in the bag.

NIC
What are you doing?

Charlie puts her fingers under Nic's nose. Nic realizes what happened. She swats her hand away, laughing.

NIC
Ew! Gross!

CHARLIE
It's not funny! I don't have a phone.

Nic looks at the rice bag and starts laughing again.

SLAP! A bag of Sour Patch Kids hits Nic in the chest. Nic's eyes go big. A big smile.

CHARLIE
You still like those?

Nic grabs a handful of Sour Patch Kids and stuffs them in her mouth.

NIC
Dude, one time I ate so many of these I got this crazy pain in my chest, and I thought I was having a heart attack, so I went to the ER, but really it was just a fart.

CHARLIE
Yeah, I know. I was there.

Nic has a bunch of sugar on her face. Charlie wipes it off.

CHARLIE
Could you not punch me in the vaj for a few hours and help me navigate instead?

Nic stares blankly at Charlie and lets out a massive BURP.

Charlie shakes her head. They drive off.

36 INT/EXT. RENTAL CAR - DAY

MONTAGE:

- CHARLIE DRIVES WHILE NIC NAPS

36A - A ROAD SIGN FOR NEW JERSEY.

36B - THEY ORDER FOOD AT A DRIVE-THRU AND EAT IN THE CAR.

36C - PENNSYLVANIA.

36D - THEY SING ALONG TO DES'REE'S "YOU GOTTA BE."

36E - MARYLAND.

36F - NIC ASLEEP. CHARLIE, AT THE WHEEL, EATING SOUR PATCH KIDS, LOOKING INCREASINGLY AGITATED.

36G - A SIGN THAT READS “WELCOME TO WEST VIRGINIA.”

37 INT/EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Nic is on her phone. Charlie drives, clearly exhausted. She blinks hard to keep her eyes open.

CHARLIE
When’s our exit?

No answer.

CHARLIE
Hey. When’s our exit? Did we miss it?

Nic stares at her phone, looking slightly upset.

CHARLIE
Nic!

NIC
Sorry, what?

CHARLIE
What are you even looking at?

Charlie tries to grab Nic’s phone. We get a peek. It’s some guy’s Instagram. Nic snaps her phone away from Charlie.

NIC
What the fuck!

CHARLIE
Sorry! I need to know when to exit.

NIC
Oh, I think we missed it.

CHARLIE
What?

NIC
I’m sorry. Yeah, it was a while ago. Sorry.

CHARLIE
Jesus, I asked you to do one thing!

NIC
I can’t concentrate, I’m starving!

CHARLIE
You just ate!

NIC
That was like two hours ago! The doctor said I shouldn't have an empty stomach--

CHARLIE
Ugh, fine! Fine! Fine! We'll get some food.

Charlie takes a sharp turn at the next exit.

38 INT/EXT. WEST VIRGINIA COAL TOWN, RENTAL CAR - DAY

A small West Virginia coal town. Nic and Charlie gaze out the window at the unfamiliar surroundings.

NIC
Where are we?

CHARLIE
Somewhere in West Virginia.

Train tracks. Homes and businesses that have been left behind with the decline of the coal industry.

NIC
Oh! A diner! A diner!

39 INT. DINER - DAY

An old bell rings as the door opens. Silence, as everyone notices Nic and Charlie walk in. It's all locals. And they're all white.

40 INT. DINER, BOOTH - DAY

Charlie and Nic slide into a small, grimy booth.

NIC
(whispers)
Charlie. I think we might be the only Asians in this town.

Charlie checks the time on the diner clock.

CHARLIE
Probably. Let's just eat fast, yeah?

Nic takes out a journal and colored pens from her backpack.

CHARLIE
Nic. Focus. Please.

Nic rolls her eyes and picks up her menu.

Charlie pulls the rice bag out of her purse and, without removing the phone from the bag, presses the power button. It still won't turn on. *Sigh.*

Charlie spots a WAITRESS (50s) at the other end of the diner. She waves at her.

NIC
I've been thinking... that I might want to maybe talk to Dad.

CHARLIE
What? Why?

Charlie keeps trying to get the waitress' attention.

NIC
I don't know, he's our dad. And I miss him, I guess.

This rattles Charlie. Before she can respond--

WAITRESS
What can I get y'all?

The waitress looks like she's been working at this diner her whole life.

CHARLIE
The Caesar salad, please.

WAITRESS
Uh-huh. And you?

NIC
Ummmmm... Can I have the burger?

WAITRESS
Fries?

NIC
Yes please.

WAITRESS
What kind?

NIC
What kind do you have?

WAITRESS
Well, we got french fries, sweet potato fries, cheesy fries, curly fries, spicy curly fries, waffle fries, tater tots, cheesy taters--

CHARLIE
She'll have the french fries!

WAITRESS
Alright. Anythin' else?

CHARLIE
We're in a bit of a hurry, so if you could let the kitchen know, that would be amazing.

WAITRESS
(sarcastic)
Sure thing.

The waitress walks away way too slowly.

Charlie grabs the rice bag and checks her phone again. She's fidgety as hell.

NIC
Are you okay?

CHARLIE
Yeah, I'm just-- I've been driving for seven hours. And I'm just thinking about work. And I really don't want to talk about Dad. Okay?

NIC
Fine. Sorry.

Nic sits uncomfortably in Charlie's tense energy for a moment. She opens her journal and starts drawing.

Charlie watches her, on edge. The **RUMBLE** comes back. Faint at first. Slowly, it gets louder and louder.

Charlie starts to cruise around the diner with her eyes. They land on every man. The FACTORY WORKER eating alone at the counter. A group of TRUCK DRIVERS. The COOK.

Charlie lands on a CUTE GUY (20s) eating with what seems to be his GIRLFRIEND and some FRIENDS.

Charlie stares at him. He glances her way. They lock eyes. The **RUMBLE** stops.

JUMP CUT TO: A 1 second slow-motion shot of Cute Guy running his tongue across ***Charlie's tits*** as she lays topless on the booth table in front of him.

Cute Guy looks away, snapping Charlie out of her daydream. He puts his arm around his girlfriend. Charlie doesn't stop looking at him.

After a moment, Cute Guy gets up and heads towards the bathroom. Charlie looks back at Nic, still drawing. She looks at the bathroom door.

CHARLIE
I'm going to the bathroom.

Charlie starts to get up.

NIC
I'll come with you.

Charlie's face, panicked.

41 INT. DINER, WOMEN'S ROOM, STALL - DAY

Charlie sits on the toilet fully clothed, shaking her leg.

We hear Nic peeing and singing in the next stall.

Charlie rolls the toilet paper and flushes the toilet.

42 EXT. DINER PARKING LOT - DAY

Charlie smokes a cigarette, leaning against her car.

Through the window, she sees Nic drawing at their table.

43 INT/EXT. DINER PARKING LOT, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Charlie ruffles through a bag in the back seat. She turns around, holding her vial of cocaine.

She looks around outside the car.

Discretely, she pours a bump of coke onto her car keys. And snorts it.

She wipes the leftover powder off the key with her index finger.

She stares at the cocaine on her finger.

She leans her seat down. And slides her coke-dusted fingers into her underwear.

Her eyes go wide as she feels the coke against herself.

As she keeps going, her eyes close.

Her hand grips the car seat.

Her breath shortens--

FLASH. FLASH. FLASH. The sound of a phone camera taking photos.

Charlie jolts up.

TWO TEENAGE BOYS stand in front of the car, holding a phone up. They run away, laughing.

44 EXT. DINER PARKING LOT - DAY

Mortified, Charlie leaps out of the car. Looks around for the teenagers.

They're gone. She slams the door closed.

45 INT. DINER, BOOTH - DAY

The food has been served. Nic holds her hands together in prayer and whispers something with her eyes closed. Charlie watches her, uneasy.

Nic bites into her burger.

NIC
(in sing-song)
Oh my god. This burger is *fiiiIIire*.

Charlie starts to pick at her food. She glances at Nic's journal. A beautiful pen and ink drawing of the waitress.

CHARLIE
You're so talented. I hate that Mom wouldn't let you go to art school.

NIC
It wasn't Mom. I want to be a social worker and help people. Other addicts.
(MORE)

NIC (CONT'D)
(beat)
She’s not all bad, you know?

Charlie doesn’t know what to say to that.

She turns the page over in Nic’s journal. Another drawing. This one is of a massive black beast devouring a little stick figure.

CHARLIE
What’s that?

NIC
Withdrawal.

Charlie stares at the drawing of the black beast some more. Like she recognizes something in it.

NIC
So what’s going on with you and Oliver?

Charlie tenses up.

CHARLIE
Nothing. He’s visiting his parents.

NIC
Okay... It’s just, you haven’t mentioned him and he hasn’t been calling you. It’s kinda weird.

CHARLIE
Well, I wouldn’t expect you to understand a secure, adult relationship.

Nic glares at Charlie. Charlie keeps picking at her salad.

NIC
I’m sorry but that salad looks tragic as hell.

Nic offers her fries to Charlie. Charlie shakes her head vigorously.

NIC
Right. I forgot. You haven’t had fries since like 2007.

Charlie smiles and gives Nic the finger. Nic sticks her tongue out. They giggle and continue eating.

46 EXT. DINER PARKING LOT, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Nic skips towards the car as Charlie walks quickly, searching for the keys in her purse.

NIC
Can I drive?

CHARLIE
No.

NIC
I have my permit! I need the practice.

Charlie can't find the keys. She searches frantically now.

NIC
So, can I drive?

CHARLIE
(still searching)
Stop it. I can't find the keys.

NIC
Maybe they're in the diner.

CHARLIE
No. I took them out when I came out here to smoke.

NIC
Why?

Panicked, Charlie peers in through the window. Nothing. She searches the ground outside the car. Nothing. She looks under the car.

CHARLIE
Fuck! Where are they?!

Charlie gets back up.

CHARLIE
Shit! Why did you make us stop here?

NIC
What? It's not my fault you lost the keys!

Guilt flashes across Charlie's face. She paces away.

CHARLIE
Okay. Everything's fine. We'll just call the rental company. Give me your phone.

Nic hands Charlie her phone. It's locked. Charlie hands the phone back to her. Nic unlocks it using facial recognition and hands it to Charlie again. Charlie makes a call.

47 EXT. DINER PARKING LOT, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Moments later. Nic sits on the ground against the car.

CHARLIE
And that's really the earliest you can come? Okay. Yeah. I mean. Okay. Thank you.
(hangs up)
Fuck! They can't come until tomorrow morning.

Nic looks at Charlie like she doesn't know how to help. Charlie types on the phone some more.

CHARLIE
Okay. We can still make it if we take a cab to the airport right now.

NIC
What? No!

CHARLIE
Come on, we can't drive!

NIC
Why do we have to get there tonight? Why can't we just wait until they come?

CHARLIE
Because, I told you, I have to be at work in the morning!

NIC
Who cares about your stupid meeting!

CHARLIE
It's not a meeting! We're selling the company. This is people's jobs, families, retirement!
(MORE)

CHARLIE (CONT'D)
Not that your spoiled ass would understand any of this.
(typing on the phone)
I'm calling us a cab now.

NIC
No! I'm not getting on a plane!

Nic grabs the phone out of Charlie's hand.

CHARLIE
Stop it! You're being a child!

NIC
Stop saying that!

CHARLIE
Then stop acting like a baby!

NIC
I'm not! Can't you see I AM NOT OKAY?

This takes Charlie by surprise.

CHARLIE
You said you were fine.

NIC
Obviously, I'm not fine! And you don't give a shit.

CHARLIE
That's not true.

NIC
Yeah? When was the last time you called me?

Charlie doesn't know what to say.

NIC
We live 5 blocks away from each other. I see you like twice a year. We've spent one day together and you can't wait to get away from me!
(scream-crying)
EVERYONE JUST WANTS TO GET RID OF ME!

Nic starts bawling. She crouches down on the ground and covers her head with her arms. Charlie stands in shock. She walks over to Nic, crouches down next to her, and holds her.

CHARLIE
Hey, I'm sorry. I'm sorry. It's okay. We'll drive. I'll figure it out. I promise.

48 EXT. MOTEL - DAY

The Country Club Motor Lodge. A very cheap looking motel.

49 INT. CHARLIE'S MOTEL ROOM - DAY

Charlie and Nic walk into their room. It's terrible. And there's only one bed.

Nic throws her backpack on the ground and falls onto the bed. She turns the TV on.

Charlie stands by the door and checks her phone again. Still nothing.

CHARLIE
Hey, can I use your phone to email my boss?

Nic hands her phone to Charlie.

Charlie starts typing.

EMAIL TO ARJUN
Hey, I had a family emergency and I'm stuck in West Virginia and I might not make it back in time tomorrow. You should have Gary take over.

Charlie stares at the email she just wrote. Her thumb hovers over the SEND button.

She deletes everything and starts again.

EMAIL TO ARJUN
Hey, I don't know if you've been trying to reach me. My phone died. We're all good for the release. I'll see you tomorrow morning.

She sends it.

NIC (O.S.)
Charlie?

Charlie looks up.

NIC
Can you check the minibar?

Charlie glances at the old minibar under the TV.

50 INT. MOTEL LOBBY - DAY

Charlie drops small alcohol bottles off at the lobby.

Through the window, she spots a SILVER FOX (40s) getting out of his car. As he closes the car door, he catches Charlie staring at him. He holds her gaze for a moment and then disappears.

51 INT. CHARLIE'S MOTEL ROOM - DAY

Charlie steps back into the room.

NIC
Charlie! It's Sister Sister! Come watch with me.

Charlie walks over to the bed and lays next to Nic. The laugh track plays. They both smile.

Suddenly, Nic turns to Charlie.

NIC
I have a genius idea.

52 INT. CHARLIE'S MOTEL ROOM - DAY

Charlie and Nic lay in bed in the same position as before, with Korean face masks on. Nic is busy drawing something on Charlie's hand.

CHARLIE
You know what's fucked up? Tia's defining personality trait is that she's smart and Tamera's is that she's dumb. That's not okay.

NIC
Dude, you have completely misunderstood the entire show.

CHARLIE
How is your side of the bed so messy already? We've been here like 30 minutes.
(MORE)

CHARLIE (CONT'D)
(giggles)
Ah! It tickles!

Charlie pulls her hand away from Nic.

NIC
Bitch, you ruined it!

CHARLIE
What is this? A dog?

NIC
A dog? It’s a baby lion. It’s Rudy.

CHARLIE
Oh! My stuffed animal? Oh yeah, it kinda looks like him.

NIC
It would have looked a lot better if you hadn’t fucked it up.

Nic shows Charlie one of her tattoos. A little lamb in the same style.

CHARLIE
Aww. Daisy.

They put their “tattoos” together. Charlie smiles even though this is way too cheesy.

NIC
I found them in a box of old stuff over Christmas.
(beat)
It’d be nice if you came home this year. It’s been kinda lonely, just me and Mom.

Charlie says nothing. She just stares at the TV.

The laugh track plays. They both smile. Nic lays her head on Charlie’s shoulder.

53 INT. CHARLIE’S MOTEL ROOM - DAY

Charlie wakes up from an accidental nap. Nic lays asleep next to her. Charlie looks at her tenderly.

She turns the volume on the TV off. The alarm clock reads **4:03pm.** This stresses Charlie out.

She tries to turn her phone on, still nothing.

Nic's phone is on the bed. Charlie grabs it. It's locked. She tries a password. It doesn't work. She looks at Nic. Nic's face is completely buried in the pillow.

Charlie tries to use the phone's facial recognition on her own face. It doesn't work.

She looks around the room. Nic's backpack lays on the floor.

Charlie ruffles through the backpack. She takes out a small stuffed lamb. Some prescription pill bottles. A wallet.

She opens the wallet and holds up Nic's California state ID. An old photo of Nic, with black hair. She tries to use it to unlock the phone. No dice. *Sigh.*

Charlie opens Nic's journal. Drawings. Poetry. She flips to the most recent entry. The withdrawal drawing.

Charlie opens Nic's laptop, covered in social justice stickers. The laptop also has a password. *Sigh.*

She stares at the screen for a few moments.

Using a sophisticated combination of keys, she opens the computer's hacking terminal.

She types **"resetpassword"** into it.

Her finger hovering over the RETURN button, she considers what she is about to do.

She closes the laptop.

Charlie looks back at Nic. She has moved. Her face is out!

Charlie slides onto the bed next to Nic. She places the phone up to Nic's face. The phone doesn't unlock.

Charlie thinks for a moment. With ninja-level stealth, she gently <u>lifts Nic's eyelids</u>.

The phone unlocks! Nic rolls over without waking up.

CHARLIE
(whispering)
Yes!

The phone unlocks on **@tangy_steve**'s Instagram profile.

This is STEVE TANG. 28, attractive, muscular. Charlie scrolls through his photos. After a while, she spots something. A photo of Steve and Nic kissing. Another one. Dated 4 months ago. Nic looks really happy in the photos.

Charlie stares at the phone. A topless photo of Steve.

Charlie licks her two fingers. Staring at the photo, she starts to masturbate very quietly. Her face tenses up. She bites her lip. She's getting closer and closer--

NIC (O.S.)
Stop!

Charlie freezes, eyes wide open. She looks over at Nic, mortified. Nic is still asleep.

NIC
(mumbling, rolling over)
Not... the dog...

Charlie checks Nic's phone. It's locked again. And Nic's face is buried in her pillow. Charlie puts her head in her hands.

54 INT. MOTEL LOBBY - DAY

Charlie stands impatiently at the reception desk. The MOTEL RECEPTIONIST (early 20s, annoying) is busy watching reality TV on her phone.

CHARLIE
You don't have a computer room? Or a business center?

MOTEL RECEPTIONIST
I'm sorry, we do not.

The receptionist laughs at her screen.

CHARLIE
Okay... Is there somewhere nearby where I can buy a phone?

MOTEL RECEPTIONIST
Oh no, she did not just do that! Did you see that?
(beat)
Sorry, what?

CHARLIE
Where can I buy a phone?

MOTEL RECEPTIONIST
Um... You could drive to the Walmart in Whitehall. It's about thirty minutes away.

Charlie looks away in frustration.

MOTEL RECEPTIONIST
You can use the hotel phone.

The receptionist points to an old beige landline.

CHARLIE
Could I just borrow your phone? For like twenty minutes?

MOTEL RECEPTIONIST
Um... We don't usually do that.

CHARLIE
Just ten minutes. I'll bring it right back.

MOTEL RECEPTIONIST
I don't think--

SILVER FOX (O.S.)
You can borrow mine.

Charlie turns around. It's the Silver Fox from before, offering up his iPhone.

CHARLIE
Thanks.

Their hands touch slightly as she takes the phone. He's wearing a wedding ring.

The man steps towards the desk.

SILVER FOX
Could I get a few extra towels to room 209?

Charlie looks at the phone. The background is a photo of him, his wife, and their son, hugging. The battery is at 3%.

CHARLIE
Do you have a charger?

55 INT. SILVER FOX'S MOTEL ROOM - DAY

A room with two queen beds. Charlie sits on one bed, holding the phone as it charges. The Silver Fox sits on the other bed, fiddling with his wedding ring nervously.

SILVER FOX
So what do you need the phone for?
(joking)
Not anything illegal is it?

Charlie smiles. She looks around the room. Women's clothes and kid's stuff all over.

SILVER FOX
How's the battery looking?

CHARLIE
It's good. Would you mind unlocking it?

SILVER FOX
Oh, sure.

He takes a seat next to Charlie. She hands him the phone.

They're sitting super close, his hand laying on the bed next to hers, almost touching.

He types in his password slowly. Breathing nervously.

Charlie starts to rub her hand gently against his.

Slowly, she slides her hand over his. She caresses his fingers.

His eyes go wide. He turns to look at her. She's looking straight at him.

He removes his hand from under hers. And lifts it to her face. Caresses it. He drags his thumb onto her lips, pulling her lower lip down. And he puts it in her mouth. Deep.

Charlie can't believe how hot this is.

WIFE (O.S.)
Ted?!

The WIFE (40s) and their SON (7) stand in the door, holding some grocery store bags.

Charlie's face, terrified. The Silver Fox darts up.

SILVER FOX
Linda, it's not what you think!

Charlie jumps up.

WIFE
Who the fuck is this?

SILVER FOX
Let me explain--

CHARLIE
I was just borrowing his phone--

SON
Momma, who is that?

WIFE
We were gone for thirty minutes! How long did it take for you to order a happy ending from one of your sluts?!

CHARLIE
What?

SILVER FOX
No, I swear I didn't--

BAM! A woman's shoe flies in the man's face.

WIFE
(removing her other shoe)
I can't believe I let you do this to me. "Oh, I've changed. Oh, it'll be different now." I am so stupid!

SILVER FOX
Please just listen--

WIFE
And you and Doctor Roberts *brainwashing* me into believing this is a "disease"! You fucking liar!

She throws her other shoe at him. He shields himself.

SILVER FOX
Linda, calm down, let me explain.

WIFE
Do NOT tell me to calm down!
(to Charlie)
And YOU! What the fuck are you still doing here! Are you waiting to get paid?!

Charlie stands mute, shaking her head.

WIFE
This is a married man!
(holds her son's arm up)
This is our son! How dare you!

SON
(crying)
Mommy...

The Silver Fox grabs his wife by the arm and pulls her into the room.

SILVER FOX
Linda, stop! Please!

The doorway clear, Charlie bolts past the kid and runs out.

WIFE
Keep running, whore!

56 EXT. MOTEL BALCONY - DAY

Charlie runs for her life down the motel balcony.

57 EXT. MOTEL BALCONY, BY CHARLIE'S ROOM - DAY

Charlie in front of her motel room door, out of breath.

She tries to slip the key in the door but she drops it. She picks it up and tries again. The door unlocks. As she swings it open--

CHARLIE
Hey, I think we should switch hotels--

58 INT. CHARLIE'S MOTEL ROOM - DAY

Charlie stands in the doorway looking into an empty motel room.

CHARLIE
Nic?

Charlie swings the bathroom door open. It's empty.

Charlie runs to the nightstand to check her phone. She tries to turn it on. Nothing.

CHARLIE
Shit!

59 EXT. MOTEL BALCONY - DAY

Charlie runs along the balcony.

CHARLIE
Nic!

60 INT. MOTEL LOBBY - DAY

Charlie speed walks through the lobby as the receptionist vacuums the carpet.

CHARLIE
Nic!

61 EXT. MOTEL PARKING LOT - DAY

Charlie rushes out to the middle of the parking lot. She looks around, out of breath. No Nic. *Fuck.*

62 INT. CHARLIE'S MOTEL ROOM - DAY

Charlie walks into the room. She tries to turn her phone on again. Still nothing. She keeps trying, pressing the power button really hard over and over.

Exasperated, she throws the phone across the room.

CHARLIE
Aaaaah! You stupid fucking slut!

Charlie slides onto the floor. She hangs her head between her legs.

As she looks up, she spots something under the bed. Nic's laptop.

She grabs the laptop and opens it. The locked password screen. She opens the hacking terminal.

She types "**resetpassword**" into it <u>and this time, she hits RETURN</u>.

Some incomprehensible output streams across the terminal. Charlie's eyes move quickly with the characters on the screen.

DING. The Apple ON sound. She's in.

Charlie opens the "Find my" app. The map zooms out to reveal "Nic's iPhone" location.

Charlie grabs the big red bible from the side table and tears a page out of it. She draws a shitty map and writes down the address.

63 EXT. TOWN STREETS - EVENING

The sun is setting. Charlie speed walks down one street. And another. Past a gas station. Past the diner. Past some STONERS (20s) smoking weed. They make her nervous.

Charlie keeps walking. She turns a corner. No street signs.

She's lost. She takes out her map.

She turns around and walks back where she came from. She passes the stoners again.

STONER (O.S.)
Mulan! You lost? Come party with us!

Charlie just keeps going.

64 EXT. TOWN STREETS - EVENING

A sketchy part of town.

Charlie walks down the street. She's getting closer. She can feel it.

She spots a dive bar.

65 EXT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR - EVENING

Charlie slows down as she walks past the dive bar. She peers in. This isn't it. She keeps going.

66 EXT. SHADY APARTMENT BUILDING - EVENING

This must be it.

A SHADY GUY (30s, covered in tattoos) smokes a cigarette outside the building. He looks like he could be a meth head.

As Charlie slowly approaches, he flicks his cigarette and walks in.

Charlie hesitates. She follows him in nervously.

67 INT. SHADY APARTMENT BUILDING - EVENING

Aggressive fluorescent lights. Charlie walks down the hall, following the shady guy.

Up the staircase.

All the way up to an apartment door. He walks in. The door closes behind him.

Charlie stands in front of the door, heart beating fast.

Hesitantly, she pushes the door open.

68 OMITTED

69 INT. SHADY APARTMENT, LIVING ROOM - EVENING

A small yellow living room. 15 people sit on mismatched chairs and couches around a beat up coffee table.

Everyone turns to look at Charlie when she walks in. Including Nic.

STEPHANIE (45, butch lesbian), goes on.

STEPHANIE
--like I was sayin', we gotta stop gettin' the non-vegan cookies because Jeff is lactose intolerant. So just stick to the Oreos, please. I don't know why I gotta keep sayin' this.

Nic looks at Charlie like "What the fuck are you doing here?!"

Charlie stands in the doorway, frozen.

HAL (O.S.)
Are ya just gonna stand there or are ya gonna sit down?

HAL (75, trucker hat) stares directly at Charlie.

Unsure what to do, Charlie walks in and takes a seat on the couch.

STEPHANIE
Okay, that's all for announcements. Who's next?

Charlie scans the circle. A strange assortment of people.

Sitting across from her, TOM (27, very cute) throws her a welcoming smile.

HAL
I'm Hal and I'm an alcoholic.

EVERYONE
Hi, Hal!

CHARLIE
(realizing where she is)
Hi, Hal...

HAL
And I'll have twenty years tomorrow. Shit, that means I'm really fuckin' old, don't it.

People laugh. Hal's smile turns serious.

HAL
I know I should be grateful. And I am. I am. This program saved my life. But some days, it's hard to not think of the things I've lost. And this is one of those days.
(beat)
I tried to call my daughter again this mornin'. She didn't pick up. And I don't blame her. But it's been a really long time since I've spoken to her. And I just thought, or hoped, for some kind of miracle today. But I guess that ain't what God planned for me.

This breaks Charlie's heart a little.

HAL
I look out at all of you young people and I think, y'all are so damn lucky. You don't even know how lucky you are. That you made it here before you've done anything you can't undo. Don't take that for granted. If you're wonderin' if you should go back out and maybe this isn't the bottom yet. Trust me, you don't wanna find out.

Charlie furrows her brow.

HAL
Shit, I'm the luckiest motherfucker in the world 'cause I got all of you. Here's to twenty years if I don't fuck it up tonight.

Everyone cheers and applauds. Except for Charlie. She sits there, rattled by Hal's words.

She looks around the room. Notices the signs on the walls:

"Just for Today"

"A drug is a drug is a drug"

"You are not alone"

As she stares at these words, the **RUMBLE** comes back.

STEPHANIE (O.S.)
Alright, who's next?

HAL (O.S.)
How about newbie over here?

Hal looks directly at Charlie.

HAL
Yeah, you.

Charlie's eyes panic. Everyone in the room is looking at her. Including Nic.

CHARLIE
I'm sorry, where's the bathroom?

70 INT. SHADY APARTMENT, BATHROOM - EVENING

Charlie closes the door behind her. The **RUMBLE** is still there.

Charlie looks at herself in the mirror. She doesn't like what she sees.

She looks down at her hand. Somehow, she's holding her vial of cocaine.

She stares at it. Unscrews the top.

And pours the rest of it into the sink.

As Charlie watches it pour down the drain, we hear--

NIC (O.S.)
Hi, I'm Nic. I'm an alcoholic.

The **RUMBLE** stops. Charlie turns to the door.

71 INT. SHADY APARTMENT, LIVING ROOM - EVENING

Charlie walks back into the living room. She stays in the back of the room, listening discretely.

NIC
I'm visiting from New York. And...
I have one day back.

The biggest cheer yet.

NIC
I had a little over 5 years. And then... I relapsed the other night. And I don't even know why. I mean I know why. But it's so stupid. Like that can't be the reason.
(beat)
If I'm being honest I hadn't been to a meeting in a while. And I've been going through a breakup. And school was really stressful. And I guess I've been depressed. And then on Friday my ex posted a photo of his new girlfriend. And I felt so alone. And I had, like, a panic attack. And I just wanted it to stop.
(beat)
And my roommate had a bottle of whiskey in the house. So I poured myself a glass. And I knew this was a bad idea. So I called someone. And I said to myself, if they don't answer, I'm drinking this.

Charlie listens, remorseful.

NIC
And it tasted bad. I hadn't tasted alcohol in a really long time. So it tasted bad. But also it tasted so good. And then I thought I should stop. But I'd already done it. Like I had already had a drink. So I may as well go all the way, you know? Addict logic.
(shakes her head)
And I keep asking myself "What happened? Why did you do it?" And what? It was because of a fucking Instagram post? That's so fucking stupid.
(beat)
(MORE)

NIC (CONT'D)
Maybe there doesn't have to be a reason, you know. Like maybe the reason is just that I'm an addict. And this is fucking hard. And for five years, every day, I didn't drink and I didn't use. And then, one day, I gave in. And isn't that okay? Like shouldn't that be okay?

A couple people nod knowingly.

NIC
And panic attacks are really fucking terrifying. I had my first one when I was eight. On a plane. I got stuck in the bathroom. It was horrible. And after that, the panic attacks just never stopped. That's why I started using. I started smoking pot when I was nine to help me calm down.
(beat)
It wasn't great at home. Our dad wasn't around. And our mom, it was really hard on her. And a lot of the time, I felt really alone. And alcohol and drugs, they became like, my family. And I guess on Friday I was just really fucking lonely.

Nic notices Charlie standing in the back of the room.

NIC
I'm here with my sister. She's driving me to rehab. And even though this whole thing fucking sucks, I'm just happy to be around her.
(beat)
Anyway. It feels good to have one day today. And it feels really good to be at a meeting.

People clap. They say "Keep coming back!"

Charlie claps with them, eyes heavy.

72 INT. SHADY APARTMENT, LIVING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

MOTION SLOWS. Sound fades away. A bronze coin that says "24 HOURS." Stephanie hands it to Nic. Nic beams with pride. Everyone applauds. Charlie watches the scene, transfixed.

73 INT. SHADY APARTMENT, LIVING ROOM - LATER

The meeting is over. Charlie stands by the door, eager to leave. Nic is being held up by all the people coming up to her and hugging her.

HAL (O.S.)
Hey. Chatty Cathy.

Charlie turns around to see Hal standing right by her.

HAL
Didn't catch your name.

CHARLIE
It's Charlie.

HAL
That's an unusual name for a woman.

CHARLIE
Well, it's Charlotte. But I go by Charlie.

HAL
Hm. I like it. It suits you. So, how d'ya like our little gatherin'?

CHARLIE
It was nice.

HAL
(laughs)
Sure. Everyone loves their first meetin'. Listen, I gotta go. But if you ever need anythin', if you wanna talk, you give me a call.

Hal hands her his card, which he clearly printed himself with cardboard paper and a typewriter.

PUT THE FUCKIN' DRINK DOWN
AND CALL HAL
304-596-7724

CHARLIE
Oh, I'm not... I'm not an alcoholic or anything like that.

Hal smiles at her.

HAL
That's alright. Why don't you hold onto it anyway.

CHARLIE
Okay...

Hal walks away to reveal Nic, now standing alone. Charlie makes it over to her.

They stand awkwardly in front of each other for a moment.

CHARLIE
So, you’re like, the star of the meeting.

Nic smiles.

74 EXT. SHADY APARTMENT BUILDING - NIGHT

Nic and Charlie walk out of the building. People from the meeting stand outside, smoking.

NIC
How did you even find me?

CHARLIE
I’m not telling you. Don’t you dare disappear on me like that again.

Charlie lights a cigarette.

NIC
Oh! Dude! The car rental people called. They might be able to send someone tonight instead of tomorrow.

CHARLIE
Are you serious?

NIC
Yeah. They’re gonna call me to let me know.

CHARLIE
Thank God!

Charlie embraces Nic. Kisses her all over. Nic giggles and pushes her away.

Charlie takes a celebratory drag from her cigarette.

NIC
Gimme one.

CHARLIE
What? No.

NIC
Come on!

CHARLIE
Absolutely not!

Nic grabs the cigarette from Charlie's hand and runs away.

Charlie chases her through the crowd. When she catches her, Nic accidentally drops it on the ground.

NIC
Five second rule?

Annoyed, Charlie crouches down to pick it up.

As she gets back up, Tom (the cute guy from the meeting) stands right in front of her. He looks even cuter than before.

TOM
Hey Nic!

Tom walks right past Charlie and up to Nic.

TOM
It was really good to hear you.

NIC
Oh, thanks.

TOM
Seriously, that was so honest and brave.

Nic blushes. Charlie notices.

TOM
Some of us are going bowling. Do y'all want to join?

NIC
Yeah!

CHARLIE
Sorry, we can't.

Charlie and Nic look at each other.

Nic's eyes plead with Charlie. Charlie looks at Tom and then back at Nic. She lights her cigarette.

75 INT. BOWLING ALLEY - NIGHT

Cheesy bowling alley music. The colored lights from a rotating disco ball move across Charlie's face. She does not want to be here.

A bowling ball rolls down the lane and hits the two left-most pins. Nic stands in the lane, disappointed.

Tom sits at the edge of his seat, watching Nic.

TOM
That's not bad!

Nic runs back to her seat, next to Tom. Sitting across from them, all by herself, is Charlie.

NIC
Charlie, you're up!

Charlie takes a look at the scoreboard. Everyone has around 60 points. Charlie has 12.

76 INT. BOWLING ALLEY - NIGHT

Charlie's face, focused. Her eyes follow something on the horizon... until they drop with disappointment. We hear a ball fall down the gutter and the machine clearing the pins.

As Charlie approaches the seating area, Tom whispers something into Nic's ear. Nic giggles.

Charlie sits down, annoyed. Stephanie, sitting next to her, leans in.

STEPHANIE
So, where are y'all from?

Charlie and Nic exchange a subtle uncomfortable look.

CHARLIE
New York. We grew up in San Francisco.

STEPHANIE
Right. I mean. Where are y'all really from?

Charlie shoots a frustrated look at Nic.

NIC
(smiling)
We're Hmong-Chinese. Our mom is Hmong. Our dad is from China.

STEPHANIE
Mongolian-Chinese?

CHARLIE
Not Mongolian. **Hmong.**

STEPHANIE
Hm. That's neat!

BAM! We hear a bowling ball knock all the pins over.

TOM
Yes!

Tom pumps his fist and moonwalks in the aisle. Nic laughs. The whole group cheers for him.

77 INT. BOWLING ALLEY, BAR - NIGHT

Bowling shoes cover the wall. Charlie stands at the bar. She takes the rice bag out of her purse and checks her phone. Nothing.

She glances at the male BOWLING ALLEY CLERK, who is also the bartender (early 20s, looks very young).

Charlie looks back at Nic. Tom has his arm around her. Nic smiles and laughs. She looks really happy.

Charlie smiles. This is nice.

78 INT. BOWLING ALLEY - NIGHT

Charlie sits back at the table, holding two drinks. She slides one in front of Nic.

STEPHANIE
Which rehab you headin' to, hon?

NIC
The Bridge. In Kentucky.

TOM
Man, I love rehab. I'm so jealous.

NIC
What?

TOM
Yeah! It’s the best. You don’t have to do anything. No phones. Great food. You meet amazing people. I am totally jealous.

Everyone but Charlie laughs.

CHARLIE
What’s it like there?

The bowling alley clerk walks over with two trays of food.

BOWLING ALLEY CLERK
Who got the fries?

Nic and a few other people raise their hands. The clerk leans between Charlie and Nic to place food on the table. No one seems to have heard Charlie’s question.

TOM
Alright, time to make some magic happen.

Tom gets up. People yell “Go Tom!”. Nic leans into Charlie.

NIC
So, what do you think of Tom?

Charlie doesn’t like this question.

CHARLIE
He’s good at bowling.

NIC
I really like him. And isn’t he so hot?

CHARLIE
Yeah, sure.

NIC
I think I might visit him after I get out. He said he wants to stay in touch.

Nic beams with schoolgirl crush excitement. Charlie chuckles.

NIC
What?!

CHARLIE
Nothing.

NIC
I just feel like, for the first time in a while, things are gonna be okay. You know?

Charlie smiles.

BUZZ. Something vibrates.

Charlie hears it. She rushes to check her phone. It's still off. The vibrating noise keeps going.

CHARLIE
Is that your phone?

Nic checks her phone.

NIC
Oh yeah.
(answers)
Hello?

STEPHANIE (O.S.)
Nic! Your ball!

NIC
I'm coming!
(into the phone)
One second.
(to Charlie)
It's the car rental people.

Hope flashes through Charlie's face.

79 INT. BOWLING ALLEY, HALLWAY - NIGHT

A few steps away from the group, Charlie paces on the phone.

CHARLIE
In one hour? That's amazing. Thank you so much!

Charlie hangs up. She puts her hands together in prayer. A huge smile of relief.

80 INT. BOWLING ALLEY - NIGHT

Charlie sits down, impatiently watching Nic finish her turn.

TOM (O.S.)
Want some?

Tom holds up a basket of fries.

CHARLIE
No thanks.

TOM
(shakes the basket)
Come on.

CHARLIE
I'm good, I'm not hungry.

Still in Charlie's hand, Nic's phone vibrates. Charlie glances at it. **A text from DAD.**

DAD (PHONE TEXT)
Dear Nicole, I'm sorry to hear about your car troubles. And that things have been not so good with your sister. Be patient with her. She is only worried about you. Please be safe and let me know when you arrive at the treatment center. xoxo, Dad.

Charlie reads this text, frozen. She clicks through to their text thread and scrolls in disbelief through the hundreds of texts they've been exchanging.

As she does this, Tom takes her hand and drops a handful of fries in it.

TOM
I can tell you want some.

Nic rushes up to the table.

NIC
Did you see? I got a strike!

Startled, Charlie turns to Nic.

NIC
Are you eating fries?

STEPHANIE
Charlie! Your turn!

Charlie doesn't move. She stares at Nic angrily, her mouth agape.

NIC
What?

81 INT. BOWLING ALLEY, HALLWAY - NIGHT

Charlie and Nic stand a few feet away from the group.

CHARLIE
You've just been lying to me? This whole time?

NIC
I'm sorry. I didn't know how to tell you.

CHARLIE
When did you start talking to him?

NIC
Like... a year ago.

CHARLIE
A year? This is crazy. I'm in a parallel universe right now.

NIC
He's actually been really sweet and I think it might be helpful for you to talk to him--

CHARLIE
Helpful? Are you insane--

NIC
I know he left. But he's here now and he wants a relationship. And it's not like I have a lot of people in my life who want that with me.

CHARLIE
He didn't just leave. He left us with *her*!

Charlie can no longer speak. Tears gather in her eyes.

Nic softens. She knows what that means. She reaches for Charlie's hand.

NIC
Charlie--

Charlie snaps her hand away and walks off.

82 INT. BOWLING ALLEY, VARIOUS - NIGHT

Charlie's eyes, glazed over. We stay on her face as she makes her way through the bowling alley, the **RUMBLE** blaring.

She accidentally bumps into a BIG GUY (20s) knocking his beer over.

BIG GUY
Hey, what the fuck!

Charlie just keeps walking.

BIG GUY
Chink bitch!

Charlie keeps going, unfazed.

83 INT. BOWLING ALLEY BATHROOM - NIGHT

Charlie pushes the door to the bathroom open, walks in, and heads straight for the sink. She stands in front of the mirror, staring at herself, breathing heavily, as the **RUMBLE** envelops her.

TOM (O.S.)
Are you okay?

Tom stands in the bathroom doorway. The **RUMBLE** is gone.

CHARLIE
What?

TOM
Are you alright?

CHARLIE
Yeah, I'm fine.

TOM
Are you sure?

Charlie doesn't say anything.

TOM
Alright, sorry to bother you.

Tom starts to walk out.

As Tom's hand pulls the door closed, the door suddenly stops moving.

Charlie's hand is holding it open. Tom notices this. He looks back to see Charlie staring at him through the door opening.

Slowly, Charlie pulls the door open, dragging Tom back into the bathroom.

Tom steps back in. He lets the door close behind him.

Charlie takes a step towards him. She's so close to him now, breathing into his neck.

She starts to undo his belt. Tom looks down at her, breathing heavily.

He grabs her face with both hands and pushes her into a bathroom stall.

They fall into the stall, kissing passionately. Furiously. He kisses her throat. She moans. She unzips his pants. Licks his neck. Now Tom moans.

Charlie's face lowers, until she disappears. Tom looks up, his hand tightening on the stall wall.

TOM
Fuck.
(looks down)
Get up.

Charlie gets up slowly. She wipes her mouth with her hand.

TOM
Turn around.

Charlie turns around, so much desire in her eyes. We hang in anticipation for a moment, and then-- her eyes roll back. Charlie closes her eyes as Tom keeps fucking her.

TOM
(whispering)
You like that?

CHARLIE
Yeah.

Charlie opens her eyes. She notices the drawing on her hand. The one Nic drew earlier.

TOM
You like that?

Charlie stares at the drawing as Tom keeps fucking her.

CHARLIE
Harder.

Tom loves that. He grabs onto her hips and thrusts harder.

Charlie doesn’t take her eyes off of the drawing.

CHARLIE
Harder!

Tom goes even harder. He starts to hit her. On the ass. On the face. He pulls her hair.

Every strike feels so good.

As it gets more and more intense, Charlie starts to lose herself, until--

Tom finishes. Hard.

His face falls on her back as she stands there, hands still up against the bathroom wall.

TOM
Wow. You’re crazy.

Tom kisses her neck.

Charlie stares out into nothingness. Emptiness.

Tom starts to wrap his arms around her. This is too much.

As he touches her, Charlie pushes him out of the stall.

CHARLIE
Get the fuck off me!

Tom stumbles out of the stall, ***underwear and pants around his ankles. We see everything.***

TOM
What the fuck!

We hear the bathroom door swing open.

Nic and Stephanie stand in the doorway. Tom pulls his pants up as quick as he can.

TOM
Shit.

Nic sees Charlie in the stall, without her pants on.

CHARLIE
Nic...

Nic stands there in shock for a moment. And then storms out.

84 INT. BOWLING ALLEY - NIGHT

Nic rushes to gather her things at the table and heads towards the door. Charlie runs after her.

CHARLIE
Nic!

Nic exits the bowling alley. Charlie rushes after her.

The bowling alley clerk spots them from behind the bar.

BOWLING ALLEY CLERK
Hey!

Charlie ignores him and keeps running towards the door. The bowling alley clerk rushes to stop her.

BOWLING ALLEY CLERK
Hey! You can’t leave with the shoes!

Charlie looks down. Ugly bowling shoes on her feet.

85 EXT. BOWLING ALLEY - NIGHT

Retro signage lines the side of the old bowling alley. Nic cries as she rage-walks along the façade.

CHARLIE (O.S.)
Nic!

Charlie runs to catch up with Nic.

NIC
Get away from me.

CHARLIE
Please, just listen to me--

Nic turns to face Charlie and SCREAMS visceral, primal. Charlie stops, petrified.

NIC
What the fuck is wrong with you?

The bowling alley clerk emerges from around the corner, holding Nic's shoes.

BOWLING ALLEY CLERK
Hey!

NIC
Seriously, how could you do that? And in the bowling alley bathroom? You're fucking disgusting!

Charlie's eyes fill with shame.

BOWLING ALLEY CLERK
Miss, the shoes!

NIC
There were like a million other guys in there! Why would you...

CHARLIE
I don't know why--

NIC
Why would you do this?

CHARLIE
I don't know!

BOWLING ALLEY CLERK
Miss! Please! You gotta return your shoes!

NIC
Ugh!

Nic drops to the ground and starts to untie her shoes. She struggles. Charlie walks up to her.

CHARLIE
Let me--

NIC
No!

Charlie backs off. Nic looks up at Charlie.

NIC
And you're married!

This hits Charlie hard.

Nic gets her shoes off. She gets up, barefoot, and speed walks over to the bowling alley clerk. Charlie watches her as she frantically puts her shoes back on.

NIC
You're supposed to be taking care of me!

Nic starts to walk away. Charlie stands there, watching her. Suddenly--

CHARLIE
Fuck you!

Nic turns around.

NIC
What?

CHARLIE
I said fuck you!

Now Charlie starts to walk away from Nic. Nic chases Charlie down and shoves her.

NIC
Hey! You don't get to say that! You don't walk away from me!

Charlie keeps walking away. Nic tries to stop her. She pulls at her clothes, she gets in front of her and wrestles with her. Until Charlie finally stops and shoves Nic away.

CHARLIE
I don't want to take care of you! Don't you see that?

Nic stares at Charlie, shocked and hurt.

CHARLIE
I've taken care of you our whole fucking lives!
(beat)
You wanna talk about Dad? You wanna talk about the day he walked out on us while Mom was slitting her wrists in the bathtub?

Nic, speechless.

CHARLIE
You wanna talk about Mom? About every time she was too depressed to feed us?
(MORE)

CHARLIE (CONT'D)
Or every time she lost it and...
(can't say it out loud)
And you! Every time you got high. Every time you didn't come home. Or came home too fucked up. Every time you got sober and every time you relapsed. Why do you think I moved to New York? Why did you have to follow me?
(beat)
Now I'm stuck here in the middle of nowhere! Because of you! And I could lose my job. Because you're too afraid to get on a fucking plane! What do you want from me?

The weight of Charlie's honesty falls on the both of them.

NIC
I don't want anything from you. Ever.

Nic puts her backpack on. And walks away.

Charlie stands there, wrecked.

86 INT. BOWLING ALLEY - NIGHT

Charlie wanders back to the group's table. Everyone is gone.

She sits down. The disco ball lights move across her face as her gaze gets lost on the horizon.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
Hey Oliver...

87 INT. MOTEL LOBBY - NIGHT

Charlie stands at the reception desk, using the motel landline. In the background, the sound of reality TV.

CHARLIE
It's Charlie. I know you said not to call. It's just, my phone is dead and I don't know any other numbers... I think I really fucked up with Nic... Sorry, I don't even know why I'm calling. Sorry.

Charlie hangs up.

The receptionist sits behind the desk, watching her show.

CHARLIE
Could you call me a cab for the airport, please?

MOTEL RECEPTIONIST
Sure thing, hun.
(beat)
Oh, I almost forgot. Someone's here to see you. Your dad, I think?

Charlie's face drops.

88 EXT. MOTEL PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Charlie walks out cautiously.

A man stands just outside, his back turned to us. He turns around, to reveal--

A Chinese man in 50s wearing Hertz overalls and a mechanic's hat. A big yellow Hertz van parked right behind. This is the LOCKSMITH.

Charlie smiles and shakes her head in disbelief.

89 EXT. DINER, PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Charlie leans on her rental car while the locksmith works on cutting her a new key out of his van. He keeps banging on his machine and swearing in Chinese under his breath.

CHARLIE
How much longer will this take?

LOCKSMITH
10 minutes, miss. Sorry, this machine not work very well anymore.
(beat)
You not from around here?

CHARLIE
I'm from New York.

LOCKSMITH
No, you from China.

Charlie smiles.

CHARLIE
My dad is from China.

LOCKSMITH
What bring you to West Virginia?

CHARLIE
I was driving my sister to Kentucky.

LOCKSMITH
That's nice. Where your sister now?

CHARLIE
(painful pause)
Where are you from in China?

LOCKSMITH
I come from Sichuan province. Chengdu. You know Chengdu?

CHARLIE
Not really. I haven't been to China in a long time.

LOCKSMITH
Chengdu is very beautiful, very traditional part of China. And best food. Very spicy. You speak Chinese?

CHARLIE
No.

LOCKSMITH
(shakes his head)
Aiya... Your father never teach you?

CHARLIE
No.

LOCKSMITH
Is a shame. Too many Chinese in America don't speak Chinese.

The locksmith keeps working in silence for a bit. Then he wipes his hands on his rag and turns around to face Charlie.

LOCKSMITH
You the big sister?

Charlie nods.

LOCKSMITH
You know how to say big sister in Chinese?

Charlie shakes her head.

LOCKSMITH
We say *jiějiě*. And little sister is *mèimei*.

The Chinese characters appear as he says the words:
姐姐，妹妹

Charlie whispers the words. Like she knew them a long time ago. The locksmith goes back to working on the key.

LOCKSMITH
At least today you learn some Chinese.

90 INT/EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - NIGHT

It's pitch black outside. And quiet.

Headlights light up the road, as Charlie drives fast.

She glances at a paper map, laid out on the passenger's seat. Circled in red: "**West Virginia International Airport**".

91 EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY GAS STATION - NIGHT

Charlie fills the car with gas. She checks her pack of cigarettes. It's empty.

92 INT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY GAS STATION - NIGHT

Charlie places some Sour Patch Kids and a Diet Coke on the checkout counter. The CASHIER (20s, hates working here) starts to ring her up.

CHARLIE
And a pack of Marlboro Gold, please.

Out the window, Charlie sees an ABANDONED LITTLE GIRL (6, brunette) sitting by herself.

CASHIER
Cash or card?

93 EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY GAS STATION - NIGHT

Charlie walks out of the gas station and starts to head to her car. Halfway there, she stops. She looks back.

The little girl is still there, sitting alone on the sidewalk, drawing with a stick in a pile of mud.

Charlie looks around. There's no one else here. She walks up to the girl. As she gets close, she realizes the pile of mud is actually vomit.

CHARLIE
Hey there. Are your parents nearby?

The little girl looks up at Charlie but doesn't say anything. Charlie sits down next to her.

CHARLIE
I'm Charlie. What's your name?

The little girl just keeps drawing in the vomit.

Charlie notices a big, nasty bruise on the girl's neck, hidden under her hair.

She inspects the rest of her body. More bruises on her arms.

94 INT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY GAS STATION - NIGHT

Charlie walks back in, holding the girl by the hand.

CHARLIE
Can I use your phone?

The cashier points to a sign with a big red X over a drawing of a phone that says "You cannot use our phone."

CHARLIE
Listen. This girl is all alone. And she's hurt. We have to call someone.

The cashier peers over the counter. She looks at the girl, then back at Charlie, unsure of what to do next.

CHARLIE
Come on!

The cashier reaches for her cellphone.

GIRL'S MOM (O.S.)
Hey! What are you doing?

Charlie turns around. The GIRL'S MOM (30s) stands between two aisles, holding a bag of chips, looking scared and angry.

CHARLIE
Is this your daughter?

GIRL'S MOM
It sure is!

CHARLIE
(to the little girl)
Is this your mom?

The girl nods.

CHARLIE
Did you do this to her?

GIRL'S MOM
What?

CHARLIE
She's covered in bruises. Did you do this to her?

GIRL'S MOM
What in the hell are you talkin' about?

CASHIER
What's going on here?

CHARLIE
(to the cashier)
Call the police.

The little girl starts to cry.

GIRL'S MOM
Baby, it's okay, I'm right here.
(to Charlie)
Hand me my daughter back right now!

CHARLIE
She's not going anywhere with you.
(to the cashier)
Did you hear what I said? Call the police!

GIRL'S MOM
That's right, call the police on this crazy bitch! Let go of my daughter!

The cashier dials 911.

CASHIER
(in the background)
Hi, there's a woman here who's holding a little girl--

The girl's mom steps over to Charlie and tries to pull the little girl away from her.

Charlie shoves the mother away and pulls the girl in closer. The girl is now crying very loudly, clearly terrified.

CHARLIE
(screaming)
No! You do not touch her! You do not touch her! You do not touch her!--

95 INT. POLICE STATION - NIGHT

Charlie sits on a small chair in a tiny police station. A POLICE OFFICER does paperwork nearby, on the phone

Charlie inspects the drawing on her hand. It's fading away.

POLICE OFFICER (O.S.)
No, she ain't pressin' charges. I'm just waitin' for someone to pick her up... Just what this town needed. Another nut job.

The front door of the station opens. Charlie looks up. It's Hal.

96 INT/EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY, HAL'S TRUCK - NIGHT

A very old, messy truck. All of Hal's AA anniversary chips hang off the rearview mirror, next to a big Jesus cross.

Charlie sits in the passenger's seat in silence, while Hal drives, mid-laughter.

HAL
I gotta say, when I met you today, I did not think I'd be pickin' your ass up from jail for attempted kidnappin'. God always finds a way to surprise me.

CHARLIE
That's not what happened.

HAL
Hey, I know how that goes. So where's your sister at?

CHARLIE
I don't know.

HAL
Ain't you takin' her to rehab?

CHARLIE
Nope. Not anymore.

HAL
Hm.
(spits out the window)
How'd that happen?

Charlie doesn't answer. She stares at the Jesus cross.

CHARLIE
Why are AA people so obsessed with God?

HAL
Better to be obsessed with God than drinkin', don't you think?

CHARLIE
Debatable. So you really believe there's a guy in the sky who just controls everything?

HAL
I don't know about that. But if you'd lived through some of the miracles I've lived through, you'd believe in somethin'.

Charlie notices an old photo of Hal and his daughter, taped to the dashboard.

CHARLIE
But your daughter still doesn't talk to you.

HAL
That's right.

CHARLIE
What if she never does? You're saying that's God's will for you?

HAL
I guess so.

CHARLIE
And you're fine with that?

HAL
I ain't really got a choice there, do I?

Charlie stares at the photo of Hal and his daughter. The girl looks 8 years old. They look so happy together.

CHARLIE
What did you do? For her to stop talking to you?

Hal doesn't say anything yet. He stares ahead heavily.

HAL
A lot of things. Some I can't even remember. Some I wish I could forget. Truth is, I probably don't deserve another chance with her.

The **RUMBLE** emerges as Charlie considers Hal's words.

CHARLIE
I haven't spoken to my dad in ten years.
(beat)
He did something really fucked up. And he left and moved back to China. And for a while we stayed in touch. But at some point, I stopped trying. And then, he stopped. And then nothing. And it was all fine. But a year ago, he started calling again. He calls every week. And I just don't answer.
(beat)
And I don't even know why he's doing this. What does he want? Like, what could he even have to say?

Hal looks at Charlie, feeling for her.

HAL
What would you want him to say?

This question rattles Charlie. A lot.

The **RUMBLE** gets louder. So fucking loud. Too loud to handle, until--

CHARLIE
Stop the car.

HAL
What?

CHARLIE
Stop the car!

HAL
Whoa, calm down. I'm just tryin' to help here--

CHARLIE
I don't need help!

Charlie opens the car door, the truck still in motion. Hal slams the breaks. Charlie jumps out.

HAL
What the hell!

97 EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY - NIGHT

Charlie power walks away from the truck. Hal jumps out of the truck and goes after her.

CHARLIE
I'll walk the rest of the way!
Thank you for the ride!

HAL
Charlotte!

CHARLIE
Don't call me that!

HAL
Just wait a minute!

CHARLIE
You don't even know me!

HAL
I'm not leavin' you out here by yourself, you crazy little...
Charlotte!

CHARLIE
(turns to face him, screams)
I said, don't call me that!

HAL
Alright! But you got another thing comin' if you think I'm leavin' you right now. Because I've been prayin' every day for twenty years to make amends to my daughter. And then one day, out of nowhere, this young lady with the same name as her just shows up. And if that ain't a sign from God, I don't know what is. So you can keep walkin', you can walk all night, I will be right behind you.

Charlie stands there, staring at Hal.

CHARLIE
What do you want from me?

Hal says nothing. He looks at Charlie with tenderness.

CHARLIE
I have to get home. I'm gonna lose my job--

HAL
Is that really what you're worried about losin'? Your job?

This hits Charlie.

CHARLIE
I can't help her! Look at me. I can't help anyone. I tried to help her. And I fucked up. I made it so much worse. I need to go.

HAL
Alright then. Go. Leave her here.

Charlie doesn't move.

HAL
Go! Go on and run home and keep runnin' from everythin'.
(MORE)

HAL (CONT'D)
And then, ten, twenty, thirty years from now, you can ride around all alone in your truck with a photo of her that's so old you can't even remember what she looks like.

Tears fall down Hal's cheeks.

Charlie looks out at the darkness ahead of her. She knows he's right. She turns back towards him.

CHARLIE
What if I've done something unforgivable?

HAL
So what? I've done a million unforgivable things.

98 INT/EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - NIGHT

The night moves fast through the window, as Charlie speeds on the highway, determined.

99 INT/EXT. WV HIGHWAY INTERSECTION, RENTAL CAR - NIGHT

Charlie stops at an intersection. She looks at her map.

Oh no. She's lost.

CHARLIE
Shit!

She notices the rice bag peeking out of her purse.

She grabs it.

Takes her phone out of the bag.

Holding onto it with both hands, she closes her eyes.

CHARLIE
(whispering)
Please...

Charlie opens her eyes. She presses the power button. Nothing happens.

She keeps pressing.

CHARLIE
Come on...

A breath, and then--

It turns on.

The Apple logo on the screen lights up Charlie's whole face. She can't believe it.

Lots of notifications. Missed calls from Mom. A notification from Tinder saying "You have 53 unread messages." Texts from Akeem. From Arjun. From her lawyer.

She swipes all of them away and opens the Find My app. A map of the area loads. She zooms out to see Nic's location.

Charlie puts the car in gear and speeds off.

100 INT/EXT. WEST VIRGINIA HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - NIGHT

Charlie's phone dials out on speakerphone as she drives. Ring... Ring....

NIC'S VOICEMAIL (PHONE SPEAKER)
Hi, this is Nicole Xu, please leave a message--

Charlie hangs up. She pulls up the map on her phone. Her arrow gets closer and closer to Nic's location.

As she speeds through the night, we hear the following voicemail--

NIC (V.O.)
(singing)
Happy birthday to you, Happy birthday to you, Happy birthday dear Charlie...
(laughs)
Man I really thought you were gonna pick up this time. Damn. DAAAAMN!
(beat)
Hey, remember when we were little and I'd always bake you a birthday cake? I'd spend hours getting the recipe and the decorations right. But it would always turn out like shit. I just wanted you to like it so bad. Do you remember that?
(laughs)
Hey, if I bake you a cake, will you pick up? Pick up, pick up, pick up, pick up, pick UUUUP.
(exhales)
Well. Happy birthday. I miss you.

101 INT/EXT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR, RENTAL CAR - NIGHT

Charlie stops the car. A big “BAR” neon sign reflects off the car window.

She looks at the phone. This is definitely where Nic is. She looks up, scared.

102 EXT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR - NIGHT

About to pull the front door open, Charlie hears her phone vibrating. She reaches for it, eyes full of hope.

It’s ARJUN calling. Charlie hesitates. She picks up.

ARJUN (V.O.)
Charlie! What the fuck is going on? I’ve been trying you for hours. There was a security bug, Gary’s team fixed it--

CHARLIE
Hey, I’m really sorry, but I’m not going to make the release tomorrow.

ARJUN (V.O.)
What? Why?

CHARLIE
I’m sorry. I’m sorry. I’m in West Virginia. I’m dealing with a family emergency. It’s my sister--

ARJUN (V.O.)
Oh spare me! Family emergency? You’re at some bar, getting loaded and picking up a married guy. Fuck! After everything we’ve gone through together? Bali... Fucking Mallorca? Just this once, could you think with your head instead of your cunt and show up for what you need to show up for?

Charlie doesn’t say anything. She just stares angrily into the distance and breathes into the phone.

ARJUN (V.O.)
Charlie! You said I could count on you--

Charlie hangs up. She blocks his number. And she opens the door to the bar.

103 INT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR - NIGHT

Charlie barges in. The people in the bar notice her entrance. She looks around. Nic isn't here.

104 INT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR, BATHROOM - NIGHT

Charlie runs into the bathroom. It's empty. She dials NIC.

BUZZ. BUZZ. We hear a phone vibrating. It's coming from one of the stalls.

Charlie walks up to the stall. She stops in front of it.

CHARLIE
Nic?

No answer. Charlie pushes the stall door open.

It's empty. Nic's phone sits on the toilet paper dispenser, with an empty beer glass on top of it.

Charlie picks up the glass. She can see a few drops of beer are left in it. *Oh no.*

105 INT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR - NIGHT

Charlie walks out of the bathroom. She looks out at the room and its few patrons.

Desperate, she yells out--

CHARLIE
Has anyone seen an Asian girl with pink hair?

SOMEONE (O.S.)
Shut up!

Someone else bursts out laughing.

Charlie looks around, hopeless.

The BARTENDER (80s, tiny old lady with no teeth) stands behind the bar, pointing to a small door in the back.

106 INT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR, STAIRCASE - NIGHT

Charlie makes her way down the dark, dodgy staircase. Muffled music gets louder and louder with every step.

At the bottom of the staircase, another door. She pushes it open slowly.

107 INT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR, BASEMENT - NIGHT

Blue light from a flat screen TV fills the room, a makeshift karaoke lounge.

Nic stands in front of the TV, in a bra and no shirt, singing "Jolene" by Dolly Parton into a microphone as the lyrics cross the screen behind her. She's clearly wasted.

One guy, KEVIN (20s), tries to dance with Nic. Another one, ALAN (30s), lays on the couch, lighting a joint.

Laying out on the table: empty shot glasses, cocaine, and loose weed.

Charlie watches Nic. Nic doesn't see her yet.

KEVIN
Woo! Sing it, sister!

ALAN
I would have never thought a China girl could sing country like that.

Kevin notices Charlie.

KEVIN
Well hello, there. Who is this?

Nic turns around and sees Charlie. She looks angry at first, but then softens.

NIC
(into the mic)
Guys! This is Charlie! My big sisteeeeeeer!

Nic runs to hug Charlie, then drags her into the room.

NIC
(caressing Charlie's face)
Isn't she pretty? She's so much prettier than me. That's why guys like her better. But I'm sexy too. I can get guys too! See, Charlie?

Charlie watches this, very uncomfortable.

CHARLIE
Come on. It's time to go.

KEVIN
Hey, come on!

ALAN
We're havin' fun!

NIC
What? No! I don't wanna go!

CHARLIE
Nic, I'm serious, let's go!

KYLE (O.S.)
She said she don't wanna go.

KYLE (30s, face tattoo) stands in the doorway holding four beer bottles. He sits down on the couch, opens a beer with his teeth, and takes a sip.

KYLE
So why don't you leave her alone.

Charlie can tell this is a really bad vibe. She grabs Nic's shirt from the floor and takes her by the arm.

CHARLIE
We're going. Where's your bag?

NIC
No! Let go!

CHARLIE
(dragging her harder)
Nic, stop it!

Nic fights Charlie and pushes her off violently. Charlie falls down on the floor.

NIC
I'm not leaving! You're not my mom!

ALAN
Oh shiiit! Sister fight!

KEVIN
(laughing)
Yeah, you're not her mom!

Nic picks up the mic.

NIC
Put on Fleetwood Mac.

KEVIN
Yes, ma'am.

CHARLIE
Fine.

Charlie gets up, walks up to the couch, and sits down next to the guys.

CHARLIE
We'll stay.

Charlie grabs Kyle's beer and takes a sip from it.

ALAN
Right on, let's fuckin' party!

Nic notices the guys staring lustfully at Charlie. She doesn't like it.

NIC
You want to stay?

Nic drops the mic. She walks up to the coffee table, kneels down, pours herself a shot of Fireball, and downs it.

NIC
You want to stay and watch this, big sis?

Charlie stares at her without budging.

Nic does a line of coke off the table.

NIC
You like watching me?

Nic wipes the powder from under her nose and licks it off her finger.

Charlie doesn't say anything. They continue to stare each other down.

NIC
Who wants a blowjob?

CHARLIE
Nic!

NIC
What? What's the big deal? Is it gross because they're strangers? Or because we're in public?
(serious)
Who wants a fucking blowjob?

Kevin, now sitting in an old armchair, raises his hand.

Nic crawls towards him. She attempts to do so seductively, but she's too drunk and it just feels... messy. Still, Kevin can't believe how lucky he is.

Nic kneels in front of Kevin. She unzips his pants slowly. She looks back at Charlie as she's about to go for it. Charlie shakes her head, begging Nic to stop.

Alan and Kyle throw a look at each other, like "is this really fucking happening?"

Nic turns back to face Kevin's dick. She moves her face close to it, so close. She opens her mouth. And as she puts it in--

She throws up. Kevin jumps back and screams in disgust.

KEVIN
Aaaaaaah! What the fuck?! What the fuck?! You fucking bitch!

Alan and Kyle burst out laughing.

ALAN
She fuckin' puked on him!

KYLE
Holy fuck that is fuckin' nasty!

Nic, mid-vomit, covers her mouth with her hand and runs to the bathroom. Charlie jumps up and follows her in.

108 INT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR, BASEMENT, BATHROOM - NIGHT

Nic throws up in the toilet.

NIC
... I'm so disgusting...

Charlie holds her hair back as she gets it all out.

BANG BANG BANG! Someone bangs on the bathroom door.

KEVIN (O.S.)
Hey! Come out and clean this fucking shit up!

NIC
Fuck you!

CHARLIE
Fuck you!

KEVIN (O.S.)
Fuck you!
(muffled)
Man, fuck this shit, I'm outta here.

Nic rolls over. She sits on the floor across from Charlie, looking much more sober.

They sit in silence for a moment.

NIC
You know what's so sad? The real reason I relapsed is I knew that was the only way you'd show up. How pathetic is that?

Charlie doesn't know what to say.

NIC
Why are you even here?

CHARLIE
I didn't mean what I said before.

NIC
Yeah you did.

Maybe that's true.

NIC
I know it was worse for you. When we were little.
(beat)
I'm sorry you had to protect me. And you didn't have anyone to protect you. And now you hate me. And that's okay. But like, I don't have anyone else.

Tears in Charlie's eyes.

CHARLIE
I don't hate you. I could never hate you.

Nic believes her.

NIC
I can see that you're not okay. This whole time, I can tell something's wrong.

Charlie looks away. Finally--

CHARLIE
Oliver and I are getting a divorce.

NIC
What?

CHARLIE
Do you remember my wedding day? How I was avoiding you and Mom and everyone?

Nic nods.

CHARLIE
It's because... I was having an affair... with my boss. And he was there. And I was so ashamed. I could barely get through my vows. And when it was time to say "I do," I looked out at the crowd. And he was there, looking back at me. And it was so fucked up. But I didn't know what to do. So I just turned to Oliver and I said "I do." And we kissed. And everyone clapped. But it was all a lie. I'm such a piece of shit. Who does that? That wasn't even the only affair I was having. I'm like, a psychopath.
(beat)
It's like I have this hole. And it hurts all the time. And the only time it doesn't is when I... do these things. And the more wrong it is, the better it feels.
(a breath)
And I can't stop. How do I stop? Sometimes I think I'll die before I stop.

Charlie falls apart in tears, maybe for the first time since she was little.

Nic holds Charlie as she cries. Finally understanding her. She's holding her like Charlie's the baby sister now.

NIC
Hey, hey, it's okay. It's okay. I'm here. You're gonna be okay, I promise. I'm right here.

CHARLIE
What's wrong with me? I'm evil. I'm evil.

NIC
You're not evil, okay? You're just... we're just hurt. You're not evil.

Charlie takes that in.

CHARLIE
I'm sorry. I'm sorry about Tom. I'm sorry about everything. I'm such a shitty sister.

Nic smiles at her.

NIC
Yeah, you are.

Charlie smiles back. She dries her tears on Nic's shirt and sits back up next to her.

CHARLIE
Will you let me drive you to rehab? Please?

A beat.

NIC
Duh.

109 INT. COUNTRY DIVE BAR, BASEMENT, BATHROOM - NIGHT

SLOW MOTION: Charlie cleans Nic's face and clothes in the sink. Nic gets splashed. She laughs and splashes Charlie back. This turns into a water fight.

110 EXT. TOWN STREETS - NIGHT

SLOW MOTION: Charlie and Nic run through the streets, soaking wet, hand in hand.

111 INT. CHARLIE'S MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Nic and Charlie lay in bed in the fetal position, facing each other. Nic, half-asleep. Charlie watches her lovingly.

NIC
Stay at the Bridge with me. Just for a little while. Until you get better.

Charlie doesn't say anything.

NIC
Say you'll stay.

CHARLIE
Okay, I'll stay.

Nic smiles. She takes Charlie's hand and holds it tight.

112 EXT. MOTEL BALCONY, BY CHARLIE'S ROOM - DAWN

The sun rises in the distance.

Charlie sits in front of the room door, her legs hanging off the balcony, smoking a cigarette.

On her phone, she goes through all her notifications.

She gets to this one: **New voicemail from DAD.** She stares at it. And she clicks LISTEN.

DAD (PHONE SPEAKER)
(strong Chinese accent)
Hello, Charlotte. It's your dad. It's Monday morning in Beijing right now. I am just calling to see how you are doing. I think the weather is getting a little colder in New York. Remember to wear a sweater. Alright... please call me when you can... I love you.

Charlie sits there, silent. She replays the last part of the message.

DAD (PHONE SPEAKER)
... I love you.

She plays another voicemail from Dad. And then another one. They're all the same. Tears run down her face as she hears "I love you" over and over.

The room door opens behind her and Nic sits down next to her. Charlie lays her head on Nic's shoulder and cries softly.

NIC
Who knew you were such an emo bitch.

CHARLIE
(laughs)
Who knew you were so bad at giving blowjobs.

NIC
Dude, that's not even the worst one I've given.

They both fall apart laughing.

113 INT/EXT. KENTUCKY HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - DAWN

Charlie drives while Nic sleeps. The morning light makes everything look soft and blue.

114 INT/EXT. MCDONALD'S DRIVE THRU, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Charlie and Nic eat french fries and sip on McFlurrys.

CHARLIE
How is this so good?

NIC
I know right.

CHARLIE
I haven't had McDonald's in like ten years.

NIC
That's the saddest thing I've ever heard.

Nic rubs her temples and groans.

CHARLIE
Hungover?

NIC
Withdrawal. Sometimes it's so bad it's like this blaring noise in my head.

A look of recognition flashes across Charlie's face.

CHARLIE
Does that ever go away?

NIC
Yeah. If you stop using, eventually, it does.

CHARLIE
How did you do that?

NIC
Oh man... I ate a lot of chocolate. I drew a lot. And whenever I wanted a drink, I'd just call my sponsor instead.
(MORE)

NIC (CONT'D)
And by the time we were done talking, I'd feel a little bit better. And then the next day I'd do it all over again.

Charlie considers this for a moment.

CHARLIE
Mom and Dad's car always smelled like McDonald's.

NIC
Yeah. It was amazing.

115 INT/EXT. KENTUCKY HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Empty McFlurry cups in the cup holders. Charlie at the wheel. Nic stares out the window. The passing landscape reflects on her face. This quiet energy is unusual for her.

CHARLIE
Are you nervous?

NIC
No. Rehab's the easy part. You'll see.

Charlie ponders this quietly.

NIC
Man, it's so beautiful out here.

Nic rolls down the window and howls into the Kentucky expanse as the car zooms off into the distance.

116 INT/EXT. REHAB PARKING LOT, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Charlie pulls the car into the parking lot. She inspects the place. A big ranch. Flags from different countries and religions hang off the roof. It looks really nice here.

117 EXT. REHAB PARKING LOT - DAY

Nic gets out of the car, puts her backpack on.

Charlie takes Nic's suitcase out of the trunk. Nic doesn't notice her nervous energy.

NIC
You're gonna love this place. I hope my horse is still here.
(MORE)

NIC (CONT'D)
Her real name was something dumb like Chestnut but I call her Dolly Parton because she has amazing blonde hair and really big horse boobs--

CHARLIE
Nic, I'm not staying.

Nic turns around.

NIC
What? Why?

Charlie looks at Nic with big eyes that say "I'm sorry."

NIC
But they have a really good team and I know they'd be able to help--

CHARLIE
I know. I'm just not ready.

Nic looks at Charlie with disappointment.

But she gets it.

NIC
What are you gonna do?

CHARLIE
Go home and deal with the divorce. And then, I don't know.
(beat)
Am I gonna be okay?

NIC
Bro, you're asking *me*?

Charlie smiles.

CHARLIE
Can I call you while you're here?

NIC
No, they take our phones. But you can call me on the house phone starting next week.

CHARLIE
Okay.

Nic can tell Charlie's scared.

She pulls her backpack around and fishes something out of the front pocket. Her “24 HOUR” coin. She hands it to Charlie.

Charlie holds onto it like it’s the most precious thing in the world.

She pulls Nic in for a hug. A really big, tight hug.

CHARLIE
Maybe this is fucked up, but I’m really happy you relapsed.

NIC
Me too.

118 EXT. REHAB PARKING LOT - DAY

Nic, up the staircase, by the front door, waves one last goodbye to Charlie. Charlie leans on the car, waving back. We hear a door open and a bell ring.

Charlie turns around to get in the car.

NIC (O.S.)
Charlie!

Charlie turns back around. Nic stands on the railing, looking down at her.

NIC
You never told me! How did you find me?

A beat.

CHARLIE
I’ll always find you!

Nic’s eyes well up.

NIC
OMG cringe, you’re so fucking cheesy. Byyyyyyyeeee.

Charlie laughs. We hear the door close.

119 INT/EXT. KENTUCKY HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Nic’s bronze coin on the dashboard. Charlie drives, staring out at the road with melancholy.

120 EXT. REST AREA - DAY

Charlie sits on a picnic table, trying to light a cigarette.

BUZZ. It's her phone. A notification from Tinder. "You have 102 new messages!" She stares at it for a little while. She puts it away.

She tries to light her cigarette some more. The lighter won't work. *Fuck.* Right then--

A flame appears. Her cigarette lights. Charlie looks up. A HOT SMOKER (30s) smiles at her as he pockets his lighter and walks away. He stops across the parking lot, by his car.

The **RUMBLE** comes back.

As they smoke their cigs and stare at each other, it gets louder.

The Smoker puts his cigarette out and walks towards the rest area bathroom. As he opens the door, he looks back at Charlie.

MOTION SLOWS. He holds her gaze for a moment. He closes the door behind him.

As Charlie eyes the door, the **RUMBLE** gets deeper and more complex. A strong electronic bass beat emerges from it. It feels like **danger.**

Charlie's cigarette has burned down completely. She lets it fall to the ground.

Charlie gets up. Still in slow-motion, she walks towards the bathroom. The **RUMBLE** transforms <u>into a full-on electronic song.</u> Rhythmic. Melodic. All-enveloping.

Slowly, Charlie gets closer and closer to the bathroom door, passing the parked cars one by one. As she gets closer, she holds her breath.

She walks right up to the bathroom door. But instead of going in, she keeps walking.

She walks all the way to her car. We stay on her face as she opens the door. Gets in. Starts the engine. And drives off.

121 INT/EXT. KENTUCKY HIGHWAY, RENTAL CAR - DAY

Charlie drives, the **RUMBLE song** still there, merging with the humming of the car. Little by little, it dissipates.

She keeps driving, holding Nic’s coin tightly against the wheel. All sound disappears.

In this silence, all of Charlie’s feelings come to the surface.

The pain of not pursuing this encounter. The fear of what will come next. Denying herself in this way feels unbearable. Will she even be able to go on like this another day? Another hour? Another second?

A phone call dials out on speaker phone. RING... RING...

NIC’S VOICEMAIL (PHONE SPEAKER)
Hi, this is Nicole Xu, please leave a message and I’ll call you back!
BEEP.

Sound has returned to normal. Charlie exhales in relief. She closes her eyes. A tear falls down her cheek.

CUT TO BLACK.